RBT EXAM PREP · 3RD EDITION OUTLINE

100 RBT Visual Study Cards

Every topic of the RBT exam in one visual page, weighted like the real test.



What's inside

01–17	Data Collection & Graphing	18–28	Behavior Assessment
29–53	Behavior Acquisition	54–72	Behavior Reduction
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CARD 01 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Operational Definitions

Describe behavior so **anyone** would record it the **same way**.



What it is

An operational definition describes a behavior in terms that are **observable and measurable**: what the person **does**, not what they feel.

It should be **clear**, **objective** and **complete**, so two observers watching the same session record the same thing.

Vague or operational?

✗ **Vague**

"He was aggressive." "She got upset." "He was bored."

✓ **Operational**

"Hits others with an open or closed hand, making contact."

Tell the difference

Could two different people watch this and count it the same way?

YES **It is operational**

It names observable actions, with a clear start and end.

NO **Rewrite it**

Remove feelings, labels and guesses. Describe the movement.

How a good definition is built

1. **Name the action** — Use verbs you can see: hits, throws, says, leaves the seat.
2. **Add the details** — Body part, object, intensity, location.
3. **Mark the start** — When does one instance begin?
4. **Mark the end** — When is it over? (e.g., 3 s without the behavior)
5. **Give examples** — What counts as the behavior.
6. **Give non-examples** — What looks similar but does NOT count.

On the job

- **Use it:** follow the definition written in the plan, even if you would describe it differently.
- **Ask:** if a behavior doesn't clearly fit the definition, ask your supervisor before recording.
- **Write:** session notes with the same objective language.

Key words

observable | measurable | onset | offset | examples | non-examples

Exam traps

- Words like angry, frustrated, lazy or bored are NOT operational
- The best answer describes what the person does, not why
- A definition without examples and non-examples is incomplete

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CARD 02 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Frequency and Rate

How many times? And how many times **per minute**?



What it is

Frequency (count) is the number of times a behavior happens during an observation.

Rate is the count divided by the observation time. It lets you compare sessions of **different lengths**.

Same count, different rate

10
in 10 min
Rate = **1 per minute**.

10
in 50 min
Rate = **0.2 per minute**.

Same frequency, very different behavior.

Tell the difference

Are all sessions exactly the same length?

SAME **Frequency is enough**
Counts can be compared directly.

DIFFERENT **Use rate**
Divide the count by the minutes observed.

Step by step

1. **Define it** — Use the operational definition.
2. **Start the timer** — Note when observation begins.
3. **Tally each one** — One mark per instance, as it happens.
4. **Stop the timer** — Note total time observed.
5. **Calculate rate** — Count ÷ time (e.g., per minute).
6. **Record it** — Write the number on the data sheet right away.

On the job

- **Good for:** behaviors with a clear start and end: hitting, requests, raising a hand.
- **Not ideal for:** behaviors that last a long or variable time (a 2-min and a 20-min tantrum both count as 1).
- **Tools:** tally marks, clickers, counters or a data app.

Key words

count · tally · per minute · per hour · discrete

Exam traps

- Rate = count ÷ time, not time ÷ count
- When session lengths differ, compare rate, not raw count
- Frequency is a poor choice for behaviors of long or varying duration

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CARD 03 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Duration

How long did the behavior last?



What it is

Duration is the total time from the **start (onset)** to the **end (offset)** of a behavior.

You can record the duration of **each episode** or the **total duration** across the session.

Two ways to report

Per episode
Each instance
Tantrum 1: 4 min. Tantrum 2: 6 min.

Total
Whole session
10 min of tantrum in a 60-min session.

Tell the difference

Is the problem HOW OFTEN it happens or HOW LONG it lasts?

OFTEN **Use frequency or rate**
Short, countable behaviors.

LONG **Use duration**
Tantrums, staying on task, sitting at the table, crying.

Step by step

1. **Know the onset**
   When does it start? Use the definition.
2. **Start timing**
   Start the timer at onset.
3. **Know the offset**
   When is it over?
4. **Stop timing**
   Stop the timer at offset.
5. **Write it down**
   Record minutes and seconds.
6. **Add up**
   Sum the episodes if the plan asks for total.

On the job

- **Increase:** duration of on-task behavior, sitting, playing with peers.
- **Decrease:** duration of tantrums, crying, out-of-seat.
- **Percent:** total duration ÷ session time × 100 = % of session.

Key words

onset | offset | timer | episode | total duration

Exam traps

- Duration needs a clear START and END in the definition
- Duration = time DURING the behavior (not before, not between)
- One long tantrum would count as only 1 in frequency: duration shows the real size

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CARD 04 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Latency

How long until the behavior starts?



What it is

Latency is the time from an **instruction or cue (SD)** to the **start** of the response.

It shows how **quickly** a client responds, for example after "put on your shoes".

Before, during, between

BEFORE
Latency
Cue → start of response.

DURING
Duration
Start → end of response.

BETWEEN
IRT
End of one → start of next.

Tell the difference

Does the timer start at an instruction or cue?

YES **Latency**
Cue → the client begins the response.

NO **Not latency**
Check: duration or inter-response time (IRT)?

Step by step

1. **Give the cue** — Deliver the instruction as written.
2. **Start the timer** — At the end of the instruction.
3. **Watch for onset** — The first moment of the response.
4. **Stop the timer** — As soon as the response begins.
5. **Record** — Seconds from cue to start.
6. **Compare** — Goal is usually to decrease latency.

On the job

- **Compliance:** "Line up" → client starts walking 40 s later. Goal: reduce latency.
- **Responding:** time to start answering a question or a task.
- **Waiting:** sometimes the goal is a longer latency (e.g., waiting before grabbing).

Key words

SD | instruction | cue | onset | compliance

Exam traps

- Latency ends when the response STARTS, not when it ends
- It always begins with a cue or instruction
- Do not confuse with IRT, which is between two responses

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Inter-Response Time (IRT)

The time **between** one response and the next.



What it is

Inter-response time (IRT) is the time from the **end of one response** to the **start of the next** instance of the same behavior.

It shows the **pace** of a behavior: how close together the responses are.

Read the IRT

Short IRT
Responses happen fast, one after another.

Long IRT
There is more time between responses.

Tell the difference

Is the timer between TWO instances of the same behavior?

YES — IRT
End of response 1 → start of response 2.

NO — Not IRT
Starts at a cue? Latency. During? Duration.

Step by step

1. **Response ends** — Note the moment the first response is over.
2. **Start timing** — Start the timer at that moment.
3. **Next response** — Watch for the next instance to begin.
4. **Stop timing** — Stop at the start of the next response.
5. **Record** — Write the seconds or minutes.
6. **Repeat** — Each pair of responses gives one IRT.

On the job

- **Eating pace:** client takes bites too fast: goal is a longer IRT between bites.
- **Work pace:** time between completed problems on a worksheet.
- **Reduction:** a longer IRT for a problem behavior can show progress.

Key words

pace | between | end → start | successive | responses

Exam traps

- IRT is END of one → START of the next (not start to start)
- Latency starts at a cue; IRT starts at the previous response
- Short IRT = high rate; long IRT = low rate

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CARD 06 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Whole Interval Recording

Did it happen for the **entire** interval?



What it is

The session is divided into **equal intervals** (e.g., 10 s). You mark an interval only if the behavior happened for the **whole interval**.

If the behavior stops even for a moment, that interval is scored **not occurred**.

How it scores

✓
Whole 10 s
Worked the entire interval.

✗
8 of 10 s
Stopped for 2 s: not scored.

Tell the difference

Do you want this behavior to INCREASE?

INCREASE **Whole interval fits**
On-task, sitting, playing appropriately.

DECREASE **Probably not**
For behaviors to decrease, partial interval is common.

Step by step

1. **Set intervals**
   The plan says the length (e.g., 10 s).
2. **Watch continuously**
   Observe the whole interval.
3. **Apply the rule**
   Present the entire time? ✓ Otherwise ✗.
4. **Mark each box**
   One mark per interval.
5. **Count**
   Intervals with ✓.
6. **Percent**
   ✓ ÷ total intervals × 100.

On the job

- **Example:** 60 intervals, on task during the whole interval in 45 = 75% of intervals.
- **Good for:** behaviors that should last: engagement, attending, sitting.
- **Attention:** you must watch the entire interval, so you can't do much else.

Key words

interval | entire | underestimate | on-task | % of intervals

Exam traps

- Whole interval tends to UNDERESTIMATE the behavior
- Report results as % of intervals, not as a count
- One short break inside the interval = not scored

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Partial Interval Recording

Did it happen **at any time** in the interval?



What it is

The session is divided into intervals. You mark an interval if the behavior happened **at least once, at any moment**, during it.

One instance or ten instances in the same interval give the **same single mark**.

How it scores

✓
1 second
Yelled once: interval scored.

✓
5 times
Yelled 5 times: still just one mark.

Tell the difference

Do you want this behavior to DECREASE?

DECREASE **Partial interval fits**
Hitting, yelling, out-of-seat, stereotypy.

INCREASE **Consider whole interval**
Behaviors to increase usually use whole interval.

Step by step

1. **Set intervals** — Use the length in the plan.
2. **Watch** — Observe during each interval.
3. **First instance** — As soon as it happens, mark ✓.
4. **Move on** — No need to keep counting in that interval.
5. **Count** — Intervals with ✓.
6. **Percent** — ✓ ÷ total intervals × 100.

On the job

- **Example:** 30 intervals, yelling occurred in 12 = 40% of intervals.
- **Good for:** high-rate behaviors that are hard to count one by one.
- **Limit:** doesn't tell you how many times or how long.

Key words

any time | at least once | overestimate | % of intervals

Exam traps

- Partial interval tends to OVERESTIMATE the behavior
- It does not give a count: 1 or 10 instances = one mark
- "At any time during the interval" in a question = partial interval

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Momentary Time Sampling

Is it happening **at the moment** the interval ends?



What it is

You look only at the **exact moment the interval ends** and record whether the behavior is happening at that instant.

What happens during the rest of the interval is **not recorded**.

Snapshot logic

✓

At the beep

Client is in seat at the end: scored.

✗

Missed

Left the seat mid-interval, back at the beep: still ✓.

Tell the difference

Do you need to watch several clients or do other tasks at the same time?

YES **MTS fits**

You only need to look at the end of each interval.

NO **Consider other methods**

For exact counts, use continuous measurement.

Step by step

1. **Set intervals**
   For example, every 1 minute.
2. **Use a signal**
   A timer or vibrating cue marks the end.
3. **Look at the moment**
   Only at the end of the interval.
4. **Record**
   Happening ✓ or not ✗.
5. **Next interval**
   Free to do other tasks in between.
6. **Percent**
   ✓ ÷ total intervals × 100.

On the job

- **Example:** group of 4 kids: every 2 min, check who is engaged.
- **Good for:** ongoing behaviors (engagement, in seat) and observing several clients.
- **Limit:** short or rare behaviors are often missed.

Key words

snapshot | end of interval | multiple clients | beep

Exam traps

- MTS can OVER- or UNDERESTIMATE: it is not fixed
- Only the instant at the end of the interval counts
- Short, quick behaviors are poorly measured with MTS

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CARD 09 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Which Method Do I Use?

Match the **measure** to the **behavior** and the **goal**.



What it is

On the exam, many questions describe a situation and ask **which measurement fits best**.

Ask three things: what dimension matters (how many, how long, how fast), what the goal is, and how much time you have to observe.

Pick by the question

- **How many?** → frequency / rate
- **How long?** → duration
- **How fast to start?** → latency
- **How spaced?** → IRT
- **Left something behind?** → permanent product

Tell the difference

Can you count every instance during the whole session?

YES **Continuous measurement**
Frequency, rate, duration, latency, IRT.

NO **Discontinuous (intervals)**
Whole, partial or momentary time sampling.

Quick decision guide

1. **Behavior to increase**
   Whole interval (if using intervals).
2. **Behavior to decrease**
   Partial interval (if using intervals).
3. **Several clients**
   Momentary time sampling.
4. **Clear start and end**
   Frequency or rate.
5. **Long episodes**
   Duration.
6. **Outcome left behind**
   Permanent product.

On the job

- **Your role:** the supervisor (BCBA) chooses the method; the RBT applies it exactly as written.
- **If it doesn't fit:** tell your supervisor; don't switch methods on your own.
- **Consistency:** use the same method every session so data can be compared.

Key words

continuous | discontinuous | dimension | goal

Exam traps

- Continuous is more precise; intervals give an ESTIMATE
- Whole → underestimates; partial → overestimates
- The RBT never changes the measurement system without the supervisor

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CARD 10 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Permanent Product

Measure the **result** the behavior **leaves behind**.



What it is

Permanent product recording measures a behavior **after it happened**, by looking at the lasting outcome it produced.

You don't need to watch the behavior live: you count the result later.

Behavior → product

Writing
Number of words written on the page.

Cleaning up
Toys left in the bin after clean-up.

Task
Puzzles completed on the table.

Tell the difference

Does the behavior leave a result you can count later?

YES — Permanent product works
Worksheets, items sorted, objects put away.

NO — Observe it live
Use continuous or interval recording.

Step by step

1. **Define the product**
   What exactly counts as the result?
2. **Set the time**
   When will you check it?
3. **Check the result**
   Count or inspect the product.
4. **Record**
   Write the number on the data sheet.
5. **Note conditions**
   Was help given? Who was present?
6. **Report doubts**
   If you're not sure who did it, tell your supervisor.

On the job

- **Pros:** saves time; you can be doing something else while the behavior happens.
- **Cons:** you may not know HOW it was done or WHO did it.
- **Example:** math worksheet: 18 of 20 problems correct.

Key words

outcome | result | after the fact | worksheet

Exam traps

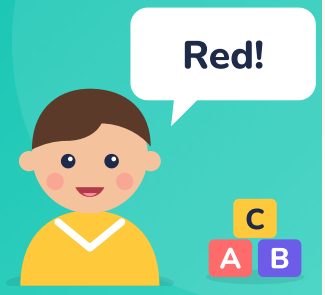
- Permanent product is measured AFTER the behavior, not during
- It can't show the process or who produced the result
- Only works if the behavior leaves a lasting, observable outcome

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CARD 11 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Trial-by-Trial Data and % Correct

Record **every** learning trial, then calculate **% correct**.



What it is

In discrete trial teaching, each trial gets a record: **correct (+)**, **incorrect (–)** or **prompted (P)**, as defined in the program.

Percent correct = correct trials ÷ total trials × 100.

Quick calculation

8 / 10
trials correct
8 ÷ 10 × 100 = **80%**.

3 / 12
trials correct
3 ÷ 12 × 100 = **25%**.

Tell the difference

Did the client respond correctly WITHOUT help?

YES **Independent correct (+)**
Counts as correct in most programs.

NO **Prompted or incorrect**
Record P or – exactly as the program defines.

Step by step

1. **Present the SD** — Give the instruction as written.
2. **Wait** — Allow the response time in the program.
3. **Score it** — +, – or P right away.
4. **Consequence** — Deliver reinforcement or correction.
5. **Next trial** — Repeat for the planned number.
6. **Calculate** — Correct ÷ total × 100 at the end.

On the job

- **Mastery:** programs often set a criterion (e.g., 80% across 3 sessions); follow the one in the plan.
- **First trial:** some programs score only the first trial of the day (probe data).
- **Honesty:** a prompted trial is NOT an independent correct.

Key words

+ correct | – incorrect | P prompted | % correct | criterion

Exam traps

- % correct = correct ÷ TOTAL trials × 100
- A prompted response is not scored as independent correct
- Use the mastery criterion written in the program, not your opinion

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CARD 12 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Recording Prompt Levels

Write down **how much help** the client needed.



What it is

Prompt data records the **level of help** given on each trial, not just right or wrong.

It shows whether the client is becoming **more independent** and guides prompt fading.

Common codes

- **FP** full physical
- **PP** partial physical
- **M** model
- **G** gestural
- **V** verbal
- **I** independent

Use the exact codes of your agency's data sheet.

Tell the difference

Did the client respond without any prompt?

YES **Record I (independent)**
The goal of every program.

NO **Record the prompt level**
The one you actually used, not the one you planned.

Step by step

1. **Know the hierarchy**
   Which prompts the program allows, in order.
2. **Deliver the prompt**
   Use the level the plan tells you.
3. **Record it**
   Write the code for that trial.
4. **Watch the trend**
   Prompts should get lighter over time.
5. **Follow fading rules**
   Move levels only as the plan says.
6. **Report stalls**
   Stuck at the same level? Tell your supervisor.

On the job

- **Example:** Mon: FP, FP, PP. Wed: PP, M, G. Fri: G, I, I → independence is growing.
- **Why it matters:** a client can be 100% correct but still 100% prompted.

Key words

prompt level | hierarchy | fading | independent | data sheet

Exam traps

- Record the prompt you actually used
- 100% correct with prompts is NOT mastery
- Never skip levels or fade on your own; follow the program

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CARD 13 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

ABC Data Recording

Antecedent → Behavior → Consequence, written objectively.



What it is

ABC data records **what happened right before** (antecedent), **the behavior** itself and **what happened right after** (consequence).

The supervisor uses this information to find **patterns and the function** of the behavior.

One ABC entry

A
Antecedent
Teacher said "time for math".

B
Behavior
Threw the pencil on the floor.

C
Consequence
Was sent to the hallway.

Tell the difference

Did you write only what you SAW and HEARD?

YES **Good ABC entry**
Objective, specific and in time order.

NO **Rewrite it**
Remove opinions like "he wanted attention".

Step by step

1. **Watch** — Observe the client during the session.
2. **Behavior occurs** — Note the time.
3. **Write A** — What happened right before?
4. **Write B** — Describe the behavior objectively.
5. **Write C** — What happened right after?
6. **Record right away** — Don't rely on memory later.

On the job

- **Narrative:** free-text description of A, B and C.
- **Structured:** checklist with pre-set options to circle.
- **Your role:** collect it accurately; the BCBA analyzes the function.

Key words

antecedent | behavior | consequence | objective | pattern

Exam traps

- Write facts, not guesses about why the behavior happened
- The consequence is what happened AFTER, even if it was not planned
- Analyzing the function is the supervisor's job, not the RBT's

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CARD 14 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Parts of a Line Graph

The standard way to **show progress** in ABA.



What it is

ABA data is usually shown on a **line graph**: each session is a data point, and the points are connected to show change over time.

RBTs may be asked to enter data and update graphs accurately.

Main parts

- **X-axis** (horizontal): time / sessions
- **Y-axis** (vertical): the measure (count, %, minutes)
- **Data points**: one value per session
- **Data path**: line connecting the points
- **Phase change line**: vertical line between conditions
- **Labels**: axis titles, condition names, legend

Tell the difference

Is time (sessions or days) on the horizontal axis?

YES Correct
X-axis = time; Y-axis = behavior measure.

NO Swap them
The behavior measure always goes on the vertical axis.

Adding a data point

1. **Find the session**
   Locate it on the x-axis.
2. **Find the value**
   Go up to the right height on the y-axis.
3. **Plot the point**
   Mark it clearly.
4. **Connect**
   Draw the line from the previous point.
5. **Same phase only**
   Don't connect points across a phase change line.
6. **Double-check**
   Compare with the data sheet.

On the job

- **Example:** y-axis: number of requests; x-axis: sessions 1 to 20.
- **Accuracy:** a wrong point can change a treatment decision.

Key words

x-axis | y-axis | data point | data path | phase line | legend

Exam traps

- Y-axis = behavior; X-axis = time
- Data paths are NOT connected across a phase change line
- Every graph needs labeled axes and conditions

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CARD 15 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Level, Trend and Variability

Three things to **see** in any graph.



What it is

When you look at a graph, describe what you see with three words: **level, trend and variability**.

These help the team decide if the intervention is working.

The three features

LEVEL
How high?
Where the data sit on the y-axis (the average).

TREND
Which way?
Going up, down or flat over time.

VARIABILITY
How bumpy?
How much the points jump around.

Tell the difference

Are the data points close together, without big jumps?

STABLE Low variability
Stable data: easier to see the effect.

BUMPY High variability
Unstable data: report possible causes.

Reading a graph

1. **Look at level**
   Are the values high or low?
2. **Look at trend**
   Draw an imaginary line: up, down or flat?
3. **Look at variability**
   Steady or zigzag?
4. **Compare phases**
   Did anything change after the phase line?
5. **Note events**
   Illness, new staff, missed meds?
6. **Share**
   Tell your supervisor what you noticed.

On the job

- **Increasing trend:** good for skills (requests going up).
- **Decreasing trend:** good for problem behavior (hitting going down).
- **Variability:** can come from sleep, illness, schedule changes; report them.

Key words

level | trend | variability | stable | baseline

Exam traps

- An upward trend is good or bad depending on the behavior's goal
- Trend = direction; level = height; variability = bounce
- The supervisor makes treatment decisions; the RBT reports what is seen

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CARD 16 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Phase Change Lines and Conditions

Show **when** something in the treatment changed.



What it is

A **phase change line** is a vertical (often dashed) line on the graph that marks a change in condition.

Common conditions: **baseline** (before treatment) and **intervention** (treatment in place).

Before and after

A
Baseline
Behavior measured with no new intervention.

B
Intervention
The treatment is now in place.

Compare the data on each side of the line.

Tell the difference

Did the procedure or condition change from one session to the next?

YES **Add a phase line**
Label the new condition on the graph.

NO **Keep the same phase**
Continue the same data path.

Step by step

1. **Know the change**
   Your supervisor tells you the new condition.
2. **Draw the line**
   Vertical, between the last and first sessions.
3. **Label it**
   Name each condition above the data.
4. **Break the path**
   Don't connect points across the line.
5. **Keep going**
   Plot the new phase normally.
6. **Watch**
   Compare level and trend across phases.

On the job

- **Example:** Baseline: 8 hits/session. After the phase line (DRA): 2 hits/session.
- **Also used for:** a new reinforcer, new setting or a change in prompt procedure.

Key words

baseline | intervention | condition | phase | dashed line

Exam traps

- Baseline = before the intervention
- Never connect the data path across a phase change line
- Each phase must be labeled on the graph

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CARD 17 | DATA COLLECTION • 17%

Accurate Data and Corrections

Data is only useful if it is **true**.



What it is

Treatment decisions are based on your data. Record **during the session or immediately after**, exactly what you observed.

Never estimate, invent or "clean up" data. Missing data must be reported, not filled in.

Do and don't

✓ **Do**

Record right away, use the method in the plan, report problems.

✗ **Don't**

Guess later, round numbers, fill blanks from memory.

Tell the difference

Did you make an error on the data sheet?

ERROR **Correct it the right way**
Follow agency policy (e.g., single line, initials, date).

NO ERROR **Keep recording**
Accurate, as you go.

Step by step

1. **Record live** — During the session whenever possible.
2. **Check the sheet** — All fields complete before you leave.
3. **Spot an error?** — Fix it per agency policy.
4. **Never erase** — Don't hide or white-out mistakes.
5. **Missing data?** — Report it to your supervisor.
6. **Store it safely** — Follow confidentiality rules.

On the job

- **Example:** you forgot to record 2 trials: write what happened and tell your supervisor; don't invent them.
- **Why:** false data can lead to the wrong treatment for the client.
- **Ethics:** falsifying data violates the RBT Ethics Code.

Key words

accuracy · integrity · correction · missing data · report

Exam traps

- Filling in data from memory hours later is an error
- Fabricating or altering data is an ethics violation
- When in doubt, report to the supervisor instead of guessing

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CARD 18 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Preference Assessments

Find out **what the client likes** so it can be used as a reinforcer.



What it is

A **preference assessment** identifies items or activities the client prefers. Preferred items are **potential reinforcers**.

Preferences change, so assessments are repeated often (even before each session, if the plan says so).

Three families

ASK
Indirect
Interview the client or caregivers, checklists.

WATCH
Free operant
Observe what the client chooses freely.

OFFER
Trial-based
Single, paired, MSWO: present items and record choices.

Tell the difference

Does a preferred item automatically work as a reinforcer?

ASSUME **Not necessarily**
It is only a reinforcer if it increases behavior.

TEST **Correct**
Preference ≠ reinforcer until it is tested.

Step by step

1. **Gather items** — Use the list from the plan or caregivers.
2. **Follow the method** — Free operant, single, paired or MSWO.
3. **Same rules each trial** — Present items exactly as written.
4. **Record choices** — What was chosen, approached or engaged with.
5. **Rank** — Most to least preferred.
6. **Use the top items** — As reinforcers in teaching, as directed.

On the job

- **Before session:** a quick mini-assessment helps pick today's reinforcer.
- **Motivation:** a favorite snack is less effective right after lunch.
- **Variety:** rotate items so the client doesn't get tired of them.

Key words

preference | reinforcer | rank | satiation | choice

Exam traps

- Preferred does NOT mean it will function as a reinforcer
- Preferences change: assess again regularly
- Indirect methods (asking) are the least accurate

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CARD 19 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Free Operant Preference

Let the client **play freely** and watch what they choose.



What it is

In a **free operant** assessment, several items are available at the same time and the client can engage with any of them freely.

You record **how long** the client engages with each item. **No items are removed** during the observation.

Pros and cons

+ Pros

Quick, natural, and less problem behavior because nothing is taken away.

− Cons

The client may play with only one item, so you can't rank all of them.

Tell the difference

Is the client likely to have problem behavior when items are taken away?

YES — Free operant is a good option

Nothing is removed during the assessment.

NO — Other methods are possible

Trial-based methods can give a full ranking.

Step by step

1. **Set up** — Place all the items within reach.
2. **Start timing** — Usually a few minutes, as the plan says.
3. **Let the client explore** — No demands, no prompts.
4. **Record duration** — Time engaged with each item.
5. **Don't remove** — Items stay available the whole time.
6. **Rank** — Most time = most preferred.

On the job

- **Example:** 5 min: blocks 3 min, car 1.5 min, book 30 s → blocks rank highest.
- **Good for:** clients whose problem behavior is triggered by losing items.

Key words

free access | duration | no removal | engagement

Exam traps

- Items are NOT removed in free operant assessment
- It measures duration of engagement, not choices per trial
- It may not give a ranking of every item

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CARD 20 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Single Stimulus Assessment

Present **one item at a time** and watch the reaction.



What it is

In a **single stimulus** (successive choice) assessment, items are presented **one at a time**.

You record whether the client **approaches or engages** with each item, and sometimes for how long.

When it helps

+ Pros

Works for clients who can't yet choose between two or more items.

− Cons

The client may approach everything, so ranking is weak.

Tell the difference

Can the client choose between two items placed in front of them?

YES — Consider paired or MSWO
These give a better ranking.

NO — Single stimulus fits
Only one item is shown at a time.

Step by step

1. **Pick the item** — Use the order in the plan.
2. **Present it** — Place or show it to the client.
3. **Wait** — Allow the set time (e.g., 5–10 s).
4. **Record** — Approached / engaged or not.
5. **Remove it** — Then present the next item.
6. **Repeat** — Each item is presented several times.

On the job

- **Example:** toy car approached 4/5 times; puzzle 1/5 times → car more preferred.
- **Good for:** early learners and clients with limited choice-making skills.

Key words

one at a time | approach | successive | engagement

Exam traps

- Single stimulus presents ONE item per trial
- Approaching all items makes ranking difficult
- Do not confuse with paired stimulus (two items at once)

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CARD 21 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Paired Stimulus Assessment

Two items, **pick one**, until every pair is shown.



What it is

In a **paired stimulus** (forced choice) assessment, two items are presented at the same time and the client picks one.

Each item is paired with **every other item**. The ranking comes from the **% of times each item was chosen**.

Pros and cons

+ Pros

Clear ranking from most to least preferred.

− Cons

Takes time with many items (lots of pairs).

Tell the difference

Are exactly TWO items presented on each trial?

YES — Paired stimulus
Client chooses one of the two.

NO — Check the method
One item = single. Several = MSWO / MSW.

Step by step

1. **Make the pairs**
   Every item meets every other item.
2. **Present 2 items**
   Side by side, switching sides.
3. **Client picks one**
   Allow brief access to it.
4. **Record the choice**
   Mark which item was selected.
5. **Next pair**
   Continue until all pairs are done.
6. **Calculate %**
   Times chosen ÷ times offered × 100.

On the job

- **Example:** chips chosen 5 of 6 times offered = 83%: top item.
- **Position:** switch left/right so the client doesn't just pick a side.
- **Blocking:** if the client reaches for both, block and represent as the plan says.

Key words

forced choice | pairs | % selected | ranking

Exam traps

- Each item is paired with every other item
- Ranking = % of times chosen when offered
- Alternate the side of each item to avoid side bias

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CARD 22 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

MSWO and MSW

Choose from a **group of items**, with or without replacement.



What it is

In **MSWO** (multiple stimulus **without** replacement), several items are shown in a row. The client picks one, and that item is **not put back**.

The array is rearranged and the client picks again, until all items are chosen. The order gives the ranking.

Without or with

MSWO
Not replaced

Chosen item leaves the array. Gives a full ranking.

MSW
Replaced

Chosen item goes back. The favorite may be chosen every time.

Tell the difference

After the client chooses an item, is it put back in the array?

PUT BACK **MSW (with replacement)**
Same items available on every trial.

REMOVED **MSWO (without replacement)**
The array gets smaller each trial.

MSWO step by step

1. **Line up items**
   Usually 5 to 8, in a row.
2. **Say the cue**
   "Pick one."
3. **Client chooses**
   Give brief access.
4. **Remove it**
   For MSWO, it does not return.
5. **Rearrange**
   Move the remaining items around.
6. **Repeat**
   Until no items are left. Record the order.

On the job

- **Example:** order chosen: tablet, bubbles, car, book, puzzle → tablet ranks 1st.
- **Why rearrange:** to avoid choosing by position.
- **Fast:** MSWO is quicker than paired stimulus for many items.

Key words

array | without replacement | rank order | rotate

Exam traps

- MSWO = chosen item is NOT returned
- Rearranging the items prevents position bias
- MSW (with replacement) may show only the top item

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CARD 23 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Functional Behavior Assessment

Finding out **why** a behavior happens, and the **RBT's role**.



What it is

A **functional behavior assessment (FBA)** is the process used to identify the **function** (purpose) of a problem behavior.

The BCBA designs and leads the FBA. The RBT **assists**: collects data and implements procedures exactly as instructed.

Who does what

BCBA
Designs
Plans the assessment, analyzes data, identifies the function.

RBT
Assists
Collects ABC and other data, follows instructions, reports.

Tell the difference

Is the RBT deciding on the function or the treatment alone?

DECIDING **Outside the RBT role**
That is the supervisor's responsibility.

ASSISTING **Within the RBT role**
Collecting data and assisting under supervision.

The FBA process

1. **Indirect**
   Interviews and rating scales (led by the BCBA).
2. **Direct observation**
   ABC data, scatterplots, collected by the RBT.
3. **Functional analysis**
   Test conditions, run under close supervision.
4. **Analysis**
   The BCBA reviews all data.
5. **Hypothesis**
   Function is identified.
6. **Plan**
   The BCBA writes the behavior plan.

On the job

- **Example:** you record ABC data for a week; the BCBA sees that hitting happens mostly when demands are placed.
- **Your job:** be objective, accurate and consistent.

Key words

function | FBA | hypothesis | ABC | assist

Exam traps

- The RBT assists with the FBA; the BCBA conducts and interprets it
- Functional analysis is done only under close supervision
- Never change procedures based on your own guess about function

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CARD 24 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

The 4 Functions of Behavior

Every behavior serves a **purpose**. Remember **SEAT**.



What it is

The **function** is what the person gets or avoids through the behavior. The same behavior can have different functions for different people.

A common way to remember the four functions is SEAT.

SEAT

- **Sensory / automatic:** the behavior itself feels good
- **Escape / avoidance:** gets out of something unpleasant
- **Attention:** gets a reaction from others
- **Tangible:** gets access to an item or activity

Tell the difference

Does the behavior get the client something from OTHER PEOPLE (attention, item, escape)?

FROM PEOPLE — Socially maintained
Attention, tangible or escape.

BY ITSELF — Automatically maintained
The behavior produces its own reinforcement.

One example of each

1. **Attention**
   Screams → parent comes over and talks.
2. **Tangible**
   Cries → is given the tablet.
3. **Escape**
   Throws the worksheet → work is removed.
4. **Sensory**
   Rocks alone, with or without people around.
5. **Same behavior**
   Hitting can be attention for one client, escape for another.
6. **Who decides**
   The BCBA identifies the function.

On the job

- **Treatment:** the plan is chosen based on the function, not the form of the behavior.
- **Your data:** accurate ABC data shows the pattern.

Key words

attention | escape | tangible | automatic | function

Exam traps

- Function is about WHY, not what the behavior looks like
- Escape is negative reinforcement; attention and tangible are positive
- Automatic behavior often continues even when the client is alone

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CARD 25 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Antecedent, Behavior, Consequence

The **three-term contingency** : the basic unit of ABA.



What it is

Behavior is understood in context: an **antecedent** comes before, the **behavior** is what the person does, and the **consequence** comes after.

The consequence affects whether the behavior happens **again in the future**.

The chain

A
Before
Instruction, event, setting, people present.

B
Behavior
What the person does, observable.

C
After
What happens right after: given, removed, ignored.

Tell the difference

Did it happen BEFORE the behavior?

BEFORE Antecedent
It sets the stage for the behavior.

AFTER Consequence
If it happened right after the behavior.

One full example

1. **Antecedent**
   "Clean up your toys."
2. **Behavior**
   Client lies on the floor and cries.
3. **Consequence**
   Adult cleans up the toys.
4. **Future effect**
   Crying when asked to clean up may increase.
5. **Change A**
   Antecedent strategies prevent the behavior.
6. **Change C**
   Consequences change future behavior.

On the job

- **Teaching:** SD (antecedent) → response (behavior) → reinforcement (consequence).
- **Problem behavior:** ABC data helps the BCBA find the function.

Key words

antecedent | behavior | consequence | SD | contingency

Exam traps

- Antecedent = before; consequence = after
- A consequence can be anything that follows, even ignoring
- Consequences affect FUTURE behavior, not the behavior that already happened

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CARD 26 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Indirect vs Direct Assessment

Asking about behavior vs **watching** it.



What it is

Indirect assessment gathers information without observing the behavior: interviews, questionnaires and rating scales.

Direct assessment means observing and recording the behavior as it happens, such as ABC data.

Compare

ASK
Indirect

Interviews, rating scales. Fast, but depends on memory.

WATCH
Direct

ABC data, scatterplot. More objective.

TEST
Functional analysis

Conditions are arranged and tested by the BCBA.

Tell the difference

Is the information coming from someone's report instead of observation?

REPORTED **Indirect**
Interview, checklist or rating scale.

OBSERVED **Direct**
Someone observed and recorded it.

How they fit together

1. **Indirect first**
   Caregiver interview gives background.
2. **Then observe**
   Direct ABC data in real settings.
3. **Look for patterns**
   Time, place, people, activities.
4. **Functional analysis**
   If needed, under BCBA supervision.
5. **Hypothesis**
   The BCBA states the likely function.
6. **Plan**
   Interventions match the function.

On the job

- **Example indirect:** the parent says tantrums happen "all the time at bedtime".
- **Example direct:** you record ABC data every evening for a week.

Key words

interview | rating scale | ABC | scatterplot | observation

Exam traps

- Indirect methods are the least objective
- Direct observation is done in the natural setting
- A functional analysis manipulates conditions; descriptive observation does not

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CARD 27 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Assisting with Skill Assessments

Help measure **what the client can do** right now.



What it is

Skill assessments measure the client's current abilities (language, social, self-care, academic) to choose **teaching goals**.

The BCBA selects the assessment and interprets it. The RBT may **assist** by presenting items and recording responses as instructed.

Golden rules

- **Follow the instructions word for word**
- **Don't help or hint unless the protocol allows it**
- **Record exactly what the client did**
- **Keep the setting calm and neutral**
- **Report anything unusual (illness, fatigue)**

Tell the difference

Did you give a hint that the protocol does not allow?

HINTED — **The result is not valid**
Tell your supervisor; the item may need to be redone.

NO HINT — **Valid administration**
You followed the protocol.

Step by step

1. **Prepare** — Materials and the protocol in hand.
2. **Set the scene** — Quiet place, few distractions.
3. **Present the item** — Exactly as written.
4. **Wait** — Give the allowed response time.
5. **Record** — The response as it happened.
6. **Report** — Send results to the supervisor.

On the job

- **Examples:** curriculum-based assessments of language and daily living skills.
- **Neutral:** don't praise correct answers unless the protocol says so.

Key words

skill | baseline | protocol | goal | curriculum

Exam traps

- **Helping the client during an assessment makes the result inaccurate**
- **The RBT assists; the BCBA interprets and sets goals**
- **Record what happened, not what you think the client can do**

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CARD 28 | BEHAVIOR ASSESSMENT • 11%

Describing Behavior Objectively

Say what you **saw and heard**, not what you **think**.



What it is

Objective descriptions report **observable actions**: what the client did, said, for how long and in what setting.

Subjective descriptions add feelings, labels or guesses about intent. They are not used in data or notes.

Subjective vs objective

✗ **Subjective**

"He was frustrated and manipulative."

✓ **Objective**

"He cried and pushed the table for 3 minutes after the tablet was put away."

Tell the difference

Could a video camera have recorded what you wrote?

YES **Objective**
Observable and measurable.

NO **Subjective**
Rewrite without feelings, labels or intent.

A complete description

1. **What**
   The action (cried, pushed, said).
2. **How much**
   Count, duration or intensity.
3. **When**
   Time and activity.
4. **Where**
   Setting and people present.
5. **Before/after**
   Antecedent and consequence.
6. **Leave out**
   Labels, feelings, opinions.

On the job

- **Notes:** "Completed 8 of 10 trials" instead of "had a great day".
- **Caregivers:** objective language also helps when talking to parents.

Key words

observable | measurable | topography | intensity | objective

Exam traps

- Mind-reading words (wanted, tried to, felt) are subjective
- Labels like "defiant" or "lazy" are never objective
- The best answer is the most specific, observable description

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CARD 29 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Positive vs Negative Reinforcement

Both **increase** behavior: one **adds**, one **removes**.



What it is

Reinforcement is any consequence that makes a behavior **more likely to happen again** in the future.

Positive = something is **added**. **Negative** = something is **removed**. Think math signs, not "good" or "bad".

Add or remove?

+ ADD
Positive

A stimulus is **added** after the behavior, and the behavior **increases**.

– REMOVE
Negative

A stimulus is **removed** after the behavior, and the behavior **increases**.

Tell the difference

Right after the behavior, was something ADDED to the situation?

ADDED **Positive reinforcement**
If the behavior increases. Ex.: says "cookie" → gets a cookie.

REMOVED **Something was removed: negative**
If the behavior increases. Ex.: cries at math → worksheet is taken away.

Step by step: identify it on the exam

1. **Find the behavior**
   What did the client do?
2. **Look right after**
   What happened right after it?
3. **Added or removed?**
   Something appeared (+) or went away (–)?
4. **Check the future**
   Behavior happens more later? It is reinforcement.
5. **Name it**
   + and ↑ = positive. – and ↑ = negative.
6. **Ignore intent**
   Only the effect on behavior counts.

On the job

- **Positive:** the client requests a toy and you hand it over. Requests increase.
- **Negative:** the client says "break please" and work is paused. Asking for breaks increases.
- **Negative (everyday):** you buckle up and the car alarm stops beeping. Buckling up increases.

Key words

+ add | – remove | ↑ increase | escape | avoidance | access

Exam traps

- Negative reinforcement is **not** punishment: the behavior goes **up**
- Escape and avoidance are classic negative reinforcement
- A reprimand can be a positive reinforcer if the behavior increases
- Judge by the effect on future behavior

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CARD 30 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Reinforcement vs Punishment

The 2 × 2 that answers half the exam questions.



What it is

Reinforcement makes a behavior happen **more** in the future. **Punishment** makes it happen **less**.

Both can be **positive** (add something) or **negative** (remove something). That gives four combinations.

The 2 × 2

+ ↑ Positive reinforcement
Add → behavior increases.

− ↑ Negative reinforcement
Remove → behavior increases.

+ ↓ / − ↓ Punishment
Add (positive) or remove (negative) → behavior decreases.

Tell the difference

In the future, does the behavior happen MORE or LESS?

MORE Reinforcement
Then ask: added (+) or removed (–)?

LESS Punishment
Then ask: added (+) or removed (–)?

Two questions, in this order

1. **Behavior** — Identify the target behavior.
2. **Consequence** — What happened right after?
3. **Direction** — Behavior went up or down later?
4. **Up** — Reinforcement.
5. **Down** — Punishment.
6. **Then + or –** — Added or removed?

On the job

- **+ reinforcement:** praise after cleaning up → cleans up more.
- **– reinforcement:** headache stops after taking medicine → takes medicine more.
- **+ punishment:** touches the hot stove, gets burned → touches it less.
- **– punishment:** loses tablet time after hitting → hits less.

Key words

increase | decrease | add | remove

Exam traps

- Always decide UP or DOWN first, then + or –
- "Negative" never means bad: it means removed
- Punishment procedures are designed and approved by the BCBA only

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CARD 31 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Unconditioned vs Conditioned Reinforcers

Some reinforcers are **natural**; others are **learned**.



What it is

Unconditioned (primary) reinforcers work without any learning: food, water, warmth, sleep.

Conditioned (secondary) reinforcers become valuable through **pairing** with other reinforcers: praise, tokens, money.

Compare

Primary Unconditioned	Secondary Conditioned	Generalized Conditioned
Food, drink, warmth. No learning needed.	Praise, stickers, tokens. Learned through pairing.	Tokens, money: paired with many reinforcers.

Tell the difference

Would this work for a baby who has never learned anything about it?

YES **Unconditioned**
Biologically important.

NO **Conditioned**
It had to be paired with other reinforcers.

How pairing works

1. **Pick a neutral stimulus**
   Ex.: saying "great job".
2. **Pair it**
   Say it right before or with a reinforcer.
3. **Repeat**
   Many pairings.
4. **Test**
   Does praise alone now increase behavior?
5. **Keep pairing**
   Occasionally, to keep its value.
6. **Use it**
   Praise + tangible, then fade tangibles.

On the job

- **Always pair:** deliver praise every time you give an edible or toy.
- **Generalized:** tokens stay effective because they buy many things.
- **Rapport:** you become a conditioned reinforcer by pairing yourself with fun.

Key words

primary | secondary | pairing | generalized | tokens

Exam traps

- Praise is a conditioned reinforcer, not unconditioned
- Money and tokens are generalized conditioned reinforcers
- Conditioned reinforcers lose value if never paired again

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CARD 32 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Continuous vs Intermittent

Reinforce **every time** or **only some times**?



What it is

Continuous reinforcement (CRF): every correct response is reinforced. Best for **teaching a new skill**.

Intermittent reinforcement: only some responses are reinforced. Best for **maintaining** a skill once it is learned.

When to use

CRF
Every time

Acquisition: learning something new.

Intermittent
Some times

Maintenance: keeps behavior going and resists extinction.

Tell the difference

Is the client still learning this skill?

LEARNING **Continuous (CRF)**
Reinforce every correct response.

LEARNED **Intermittent**
Thin the schedule as the plan directs.

Schedule thinning

1. **Start**
   CRF while the skill is new.
2. **Reach criterion**
   Skill is consistent.
3. **Thin gradually**
   Every 2nd, 3rd... as the plan says.
4. **Watch data**
   Errors going up? Tell your supervisor.
5. **Natural**
   Move toward natural reinforcers.
6. **Maintain**
   Intermittent keeps the skill strong.

On the job

- **Example CRF:** every correct tact earns a token while learning colors.
- **Example intermittent:** praise on about every 3rd correct answer once colors are mastered.
- **Extinction:** behaviors on intermittent schedules are more resistant to extinction.

Key words

CRF | intermittent | thinning | acquisition | maintenance

Exam traps

- CRF for new skills; intermittent for maintenance
- Intermittent schedules make behavior MORE resistant to extinction
- Thin the schedule only as written in the plan

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CARD 33 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

FR, VR, FI, VI Schedules

Reinforce by **number of responses** or by **time**.



What it is

Ratio schedules depend on the **number of responses**. **Interval** schedules depend on **time passing** (the first response after the time is reinforced).

Fixed = always the same. **Variable** = changes around an **average**.

The four schedules

FR
Fixed ratio
Every 5th response (FR5).

VR
Variable ratio
On average every 5 (VR5). Slot machine.

FI / VI
Interval
First response after a fixed (FI) or average (VI) time.

Tell the difference

Does reinforcement depend on the NUMBER of responses?

COUNT **Ratio (FR or VR)**
Count the responses.

TIME **Interval (FI or VI)**
The first response after time has passed.

Read the schedule

1. **Count or clock?** Ratio = count. Interval = time.
2. **Same or average?** Fixed or variable.
3. **FR** High rate, pause after reinforcement.
4. **VR** High, steady rate; very resistant to extinction.
5. **FI** "Scallop": responses speed up near the time.
6. **VI** Steady, moderate rate.

On the job

- **FR3:** a token after every 3 correct worksheet problems.
- **VR4:** praise after about every 4 responses, sometimes 2, sometimes 6.
- **FI 2 min:** first appropriate request after 2 minutes earns attention.

Key words

ratio | interval | fixed | variable | average

Exam traps

- Interval schedules still need a RESPONSE after the time passes
- "Variable" = average number or time, not random
- VR produces the highest, steadiest response rates

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CARD 34 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Token Economies

Earn **tokens**, then **trade** them for a reward.



What it is

A **token economy** delivers tokens (stars, chips, points) for target behaviors. Tokens are later exchanged for **backup reinforcers**.

Tokens are **generalized conditioned reinforcers**: they work because they can buy preferred items or activities.

The 5 parts

- **Target behaviors**: clearly defined
- **Tokens**: what is earned
- **Backup reinforcers**: what tokens buy
- **Exchange rate**: how many tokens per reward
- **Exchange time**: when tokens are traded

Tell the difference

Does the client know what they are working for before starting?

YES — Good setup
The chosen reward is visible or named.

NO — Set it first
Choose the backup reinforcer before work begins.

Step by step

1. **Choose the reward**
   Ask or do a quick preference check.
2. **Show the board**
   "You're working for tablet."
3. **Deliver tokens**
   Immediately after the target behavior.
4. **Add praise**
   Pair each token with praise.
5. **Board full**
   Exchange for the backup reinforcer.
6. **Reset**
   Start a new board.

On the job

- **Example:** 5-token board: each correct response earns a star; 5 stars = 2 min of tablet.
- **Response cost:** some plans remove tokens for problem behavior; only if written in the plan.

Key words

tokens | backup reinforcer | exchange | board | generalized

Exam traps

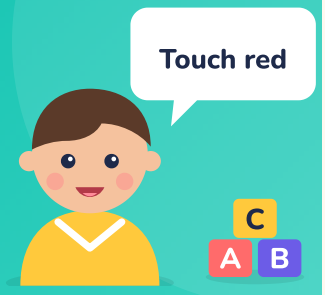
- Tokens have value only because of the backup reinforcers
- Deliver tokens immediately, paired with praise
- Taking tokens away (response cost) only if the plan includes it

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CARD 35 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Discrete Trial Training (DTT)

Teaching in **short, clear, repeated** learning trials.



What it is

DTT breaks skills into small units taught in **structured trials**, usually at a table, with many repetitions.

Each trial has a clear beginning and end.

Parts of a trial

1
SD
Instruction: "Touch red."

2
Response
Client responds (with a prompt if needed).

3
Consequence + ITI
Reinforce or correct, then a brief pause.

Tell the difference

Does the trial start with a clear instruction from the adult?

YES DTT
Adult-led, structured, repeated trials.

NO Probably NET
Teaching follows the client's interests in natural settings.

One trial step by step

1. **Get attention** — Make sure the client is ready.
2. **Present the SD** — Clear and brief, as written.
3. **Prompt if planned** — Use the prompt level in the program.
4. **Wait for response** — Allow the set time.
5. **Consequence** — Reinforce correct; correction for errors.
6. **ITI** — Short pause, record data, next trial.

On the job

- **Mass trials:** the same target repeated several times in a row.
- **Interspersal:** mix mastered and new targets to keep motivation.
- **Data:** record every trial right away.

Key words

SD | response | consequence | ITI | prompt

Exam traps

- ITI = intertrial interval, the pause between trials
- Say the SD once, clearly; don't repeat it many times
- DTT is adult-led; NET follows the client's motivation

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CARD 36 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Naturalistic Teaching (NET)

Teach during **play and daily routines**, following the client's lead.



What it is

Naturalistic teaching uses the client's **interests and natural situations** to create learning opportunities.

Reinforcers are usually **natural**: asking for the car gets the car. This helps skills **generalize**.

DTT vs NET

DTT
Structured
Adult-led, table, many repetitions.

NET
Natural
Client-led, play, routines, natural reinforcers.

Tell the difference

Is the teaching opportunity based on what the client wants right now?

YES **NET**
Use motivation in the moment.

NO **DTT or other**
Structured, adult-initiated teaching.

Step by step

1. **Observe**
   What is the client interested in?
2. **Set up**
   Place the item in view but out of reach.
3. **Wait**
   Let the client initiate.
4. **Prompt if needed**
   Model the target response.
5. **Natural consequence**
   Give the item they asked for.
6. **Record**
   Note the opportunity and response.

On the job

- **Example:** child reaches for bubbles; you wait; child says "bubbles"; you blow bubbles.
- **Incidental teaching:** a type of NET built on child-initiated interactions.

Key words

natural | motivation | generalization | incidental | play

Exam traps

- NET uses natural reinforcers related to the response
- NET is client-led; DTT is adult-led
- NET helps generalization to real-life settings

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CARD 37 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Mand

Asking for what you want.



What it is

A **mand** is a request. It is controlled by **motivation** (what the person wants right now) and reinforced by getting the **specific thing** requested.

Mands can be words, signs, pictures (PECS) or a device.

Mand examples

"Juice"
Item
Gets juice.

"Help"
Action
Gets help opening the box.

"Break"
Escape
Gets a short break.

Tell the difference

Is the client asking for something they WANT right now?

YES **Mand**
Reinforced by receiving that specific item or action.

NO **Check other operants**
Labeling = tact. Repeating = echoic. Answering = intraverbal.

Teaching mands

1. **Find motivation** — Something the client wants now.
2. **Control access** — Item visible but out of reach.
3. **Wait or prompt** — Model the word or sign if needed.
4. **Deliver fast** — Give the item right after the mand.
5. **Fade prompts** — Move toward independent requests.
6. **Many chances** — Create opportunities all day.

On the job

- **First skill:** mands are often taught first because they give the client control.
- **Reduce behavior:** replacing crying with "help" is a mand used in FCT.

Key words

request | motivation | MO | specific reinforcer | PECS

Exam traps

- A mand is reinforced by the SPECIFIC thing requested
- Motivation (MO) controls the mand, not an object in view
- Saying "apple" because they want one = mand; because they see one = tact

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CARD 38 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Tact

Naming or labeling what you see, hear or feel.



What it is

A **tact** is a label. It is controlled by something in the **environment** (an object, picture, sound, action) and reinforced by **social praise**.

The client is not asking for the item; they are commenting on it.

Mand or tact?

MAND
"Cookie!"
Wants it → gets the cookie.

TACT
"Cookie!"
Sees it → "Yes, that's a cookie!"

Same word, different reason.

Tell the difference

Is the client labeling something they sense, without asking for it?

YES **Tact**
Reinforced by praise or social attention.

NO **Probably a mand**
If they are requesting the item.

Teaching tacts

1. **Show the item** — Object, picture or action.
2. **Ask if planned** — "What is it?" (or just present it).
3. **Prompt if needed** — Model the label.
4. **Praise** — "Yes, dog!"
5. **Vary examples** — Different dogs, pictures, sizes.
6. **Fade prompts** — Toward independent labeling.

On the job

- **Examples:** "red", "jumping", "loud", "hot".
- **Generalization:** use many examples so the label works in real life.

Key words

label | nonverbal stimulus | praise | comment | naming

Exam traps

- Tacts are reinforced by social attention, not the item itself
- Same word can be a mand or a tact: look at WHY it was said
- Teach with multiple examples to avoid narrow labels

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CARD 39 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Echoic

Repeating what someone else says.



What it is

An **echoic** is repeating a sound, word or phrase that someone else just said.

It has **point-to-point correspondence**: the response matches the model. It is a key building block for other language skills.

Model → echo

Adult
"Say ball"
Verbal model.

Client
"Ball"
Repeats the same word.

Tell the difference

Does the client's response MATCH the word they just heard?

YES Echoic
Verbal model → same verbal response.

NO Other operant
Different words in reply = intraverbal.

Teaching echoics

1. **Get attention**
   Face to face.
2. **Model**
   "Say ___" or just the sound.
3. **Wait**
   A few seconds.
4. **Reinforce**
   Approximations at first (shaping).
5. **Raise criterion**
   Closer and closer to the model.
6. **Use it**
   Echoic prompts help teach mands and tacts.

On the job

- **Example:** "Say car" → "car".
- **As a prompt:** an echoic is often used to prompt a mand: "Say juice" → "juice" → gets juice.

Key words

imitation | verbal model | repeat | point-to-point

Exam traps

- Echoic = repeats what was just HEARD
- Copying a written word is not an echoic
- Answering a question is intraverbal, not echoic

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CARD 40 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Intraverbal

Answering and conversation: words in response to words.



What it is

An **intraverbal** is a verbal response to someone else's words, where the answer is **different** from what was said.

Answering questions, filling in songs and conversation are intraverbals.

Examples

"Ready, set..." → "Go!"
Fill-in.

"Your name?" → "Sam"
Answering.

"Animals?" → "cat, dog"
Listing.

Tell the difference

Is the answer DIFFERENT from the words the client heard?

YES Intraverbal
Verbal stimulus → different verbal response.

NO Echoic
If the client repeats the same words.

Teaching intraverbals

1. **Start simple** — Fill-ins: songs, "1, 2..."
2. **Ask** — Simple questions (name, age).
3. **Prompt** — Echoic prompt: "Say Sam".
4. **Fade** — Remove the prompt over trials.
5. **Vary** — Different people and wording.
6. **Build up** — Toward conversation.

On the job

- **Example:** "What do you eat with?" → "spoon".
- **No item in view:** intraverbals don't depend on seeing the object.

Key words

answering | fill-in | conversation | verbal stimulus

Exam traps

- Intraverbal: the response does NOT match the words heard
- If the client points to the answer, it is listener responding
- Labeling an object in view is a tact, not intraverbal

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CARD 41 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Listener Responding

Following instructions and **identifying** what is named.



What it is

Listener responding (receptive language) is doing something in response to what someone says: pointing, touching, giving, following directions.

The client does not need to speak: they **act** on the words.

Listener examples

"Touch dog"
Identify
Points to the dog picture.

"Give me shoe"
Follow
Hands over the shoe.

"Clap"
Action
Claps.

Tell the difference

Does the client respond with an ACTION instead of words?

YES **Listener responding**
Pointing, touching, giving, doing.

NO **Verbal operant**
Mand, tact, echoic or intraverbal.

Teaching identification

1. **Arrange the field**
   E.g., 3 pictures on the table.
2. **Give the SD**
   "Touch apple."
3. **Wait**
   Allow response time.
4. **Prompt if needed**
   Point or guide, as planned.
5. **Reinforce**
   Praise and reinforcer.
6. **Rotate positions**
   Move the items each trial.

On the job

- [x] **Field of 3:** change the position of items so the client listens instead of guessing a spot.
- [x] **Daily life:** following directions at home and school.

Key words

receptive | identify | follow directions | field | array

Exam traps

- Listener responding needs no speech from the client
- Rotate item positions to avoid position bias
- Pointing to an answer is listener behavior, not intraverbal

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CARD 42 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Types of Prompts

Extra **help** so the client responds correctly.



What it is

A **prompt** is extra help added to increase the chance of a correct response. Prompts must be **faded** so the client becomes independent.

Response prompts act on the client's response. **Stimulus prompts** change the materials.

Main prompts (most → least intrusive)

- **Physical**: full or partial hand guidance
- **Model**: you show the response
- **Gestural**: pointing, looking, nodding
- **Verbal**: words or hints
- **Visual**: pictures, written cues
- **Stimulus**: position, size or color of the correct item

Tell the difference

Are you helping the client's RESPONSE (guiding, modeling, telling)?

YES Response prompt
Physical, model, gestural, verbal.

NO Stimulus prompt
You changed the materials (closer, bigger, highlighted).

Using prompts

1. **Know the plan**
   Which prompts are allowed.
2. **Give the SD**
   Then the prompt, as planned.
3. **Least needed**
   Use only the help required.
4. **Reinforce**
   Prompted responses as the plan says.
5. **Record**
   Prompt level used.
6. **Fade**
   Reduce help over time.

On the job

- **Example:** "Touch blue" and the blue card is placed closer = stimulus (position) prompt.
- **Avoid dependence:** a client waiting for your help every time is prompt dependent.

Key words

physical | model | gestural | verbal | visual | fade

Exam traps

- Prompts must be faded to avoid prompt dependence
- Full physical is the MOST intrusive prompt
- Moving the correct item closer is a stimulus prompt

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CARD 43 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Most-to-Least Prompting

Start with **a lot of help**, then give **less and less**.



What it is

In **most-to-least** prompting, you begin with the **most intrusive** prompt needed for success (often full physical) and fade to less help over trials.

It reduces errors, so it is often used for **new skills**.

Fading down

1. **Full physical**
2. **Partial physical**
3. **Model**
4. **Gestural**
5. **Verbal**
6. **Independent ✓**

Tell the difference

Is the skill brand new and errors could be frustrating or dangerous?

YES Most-to-least fits
Start with high support.

NO Least-to-most may fit
Give a chance to respond first.

Step by step

1. **Start high** — The prompt that guarantees success.
2. **Reinforce** — Each correct (prompted) response.
3. **Fade by plan** — Move to the next lighter prompt.
4. **Watch data** — Errors? Back up one level, as directed.
5. **Keep fading** — Toward independence.
6. **Independent** — Reinforce strongly.

On the job

- **Example:** teaching handwashing: hand-over-hand first, then guiding at the wrist, then pointing.
- **Errorless:** most-to-least is a form of errorless teaching.

Key words

intrusive | fade | errorless | new skill

Exam traps

- Most-to-least starts with the MOST help
- It minimizes errors during learning
- Fading follows the plan's rules, not the RBT's choice

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CARD 44 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Least-to-Most Prompting

Give a **chance first**, then add help **only if needed**.



What it is

In **least-to-most** prompting, you start by giving the client an opportunity to respond **independently**. If they don't, you add more help step by step.

It is often used when the client already has some of the skill.

Building up

1. **Independent opportunity**
2. **Verbal**
3. **Gestural**
4. **Model**
5. **Partial physical**
6. **Full physical**

Tell the difference

Does the client already know part of the skill?

YES — Least-to-most fits
Lets them show what they can do.

NO — Most-to-least may fit
For brand-new skills.

Step by step

1. **Give the SD**
   Wait for an independent response.
2. **No response?**
   Add the least intrusive prompt.
3. **Still nothing?**
   Move to the next level.
4. **Reinforce**
   As written for prompted vs independent.
5. **Record**
   The level that worked.
6. **Next trial**
   Start from independent again.

On the job

- **Example:** "Put on shoes" → waits 5 s → points to shoes → models → guides hands.
- **Risk:** more errors than most-to-least before the right prompt is reached.

Key words

independent | opportunity | wait time | prompt hierarchy

Exam traps

- Least-to-most starts with an independent opportunity
- It can produce more errors than most-to-least
- Each trial restarts at the least intrusive level

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CARD 45 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Prompt Fading and Errorless Teaching

Remove help **gradually** so the client becomes **independent**.



What it is

Prompt fading gradually reduces help until the client responds on their own. Without fading, the client may become **prompt dependent**.

Errorless teaching arranges prompts so the client rarely makes mistakes while learning.

Ways to fade

Hierarchy
Lighter prompts
Most-to-least or least-to-most.

Time delay
Wait longer
0 s → 2 s → 4 s before the prompt.

Graduated
Less pressure
Lighter touch, farther from the hand.

Tell the difference

Does the client wait for your help even on easy, known tasks?

YES **Possible prompt dependence**
Tell your supervisor; fading may need changes.

NO **Fading is working**
Keep following the plan.

Example: time delay

1. **0-second delay** — Prompt right after the SD.
2. **Reinforce** — Prompted correct responses.
3. **Add delay** — Wait 2–3 s before prompting.
4. **Client responds first** — Bigger reinforcer for independence.
5. **Increase delay** — As the plan says.
6. **Independent** — No prompt needed.

On the job

- **Differential reinforcement:** give stronger reinforcement for independent responses than prompted ones.
- **Consistency:** all staff fade the same way.

Key words

fading | time delay | prompt dependence | errorless | independence

Exam traps

- Prompt dependence = waiting for help even when able
- Time delay fades by waiting longer, not by changing the prompt
- Reinforce independent responses more than prompted ones

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CARD 46 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Shaping

Reinforce **steps closer and closer** to the goal behavior.



What it is

Shaping teaches a **new behavior** by reinforcing **successive approximations**: small steps that look more and more like the target.

Earlier approximations stop being reinforced once the next step appears (differential reinforcement).

Shaping vs chaining

Shaping
One behavior

Gets closer to the target form.

Chaining
Many steps

Links different behaviors in a sequence.

Tell the difference

Are you changing the SAME behavior to look more like the target?

YES **Shaping**
Successive approximations of one behavior.

NO **Chaining**
If you are linking several different steps.

Step by step

1. **Target**
   Define the final behavior.
2. **Starting point**
   What the client already does.
3. **Reinforce**
   The current approximation.
4. **Raise the bar**
   Only closer responses now earn reinforcement.
5. **Small steps**
   Not too big, not too fast.
6. **Final form**
   Reinforce the target behavior.

On the job

- **Speech:** "b" → "ba" → "bah" → "ball".
- **Duration:** sitting 5 s → 10 s → 30 s → 1 min.

Key words

successive approximations | differential reinforcement | target

Exam traps

- Shaping creates a NEW behavior, step by step
- Stop reinforcing an old approximation once a closer one appears
- Shaping changes one behavior; chaining links many

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CARD 47 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Task Analysis

Break a complex skill into **small, teachable steps**.



What it is

A **task analysis** breaks a complex behavior into a **list of smaller steps** in order.

It is the foundation for teaching chained skills like handwashing, dressing or brushing teeth.

Example: washing hands

- Turn on water
- Wet hands
- Put soap on hands
- Rub hands together
- Rinse hands
- Turn off water
- Dry hands

Tell the difference

Does the skill have several steps that must happen in order?

YES — Use a task analysis
Then teach with a chaining method.

NO — Single response
Other methods like DTT or shaping may fit.

Using a task analysis

1. **List steps** — The BCBA writes the task analysis.
2. **Assess** — Which steps the client already does.
3. **Teach** — Using the chaining method in the plan.
4. **Prompt** — Only on steps needed.
5. **Record** — Each step: independent or prompted.
6. **Graph** — % of steps independent.

On the job

- **Data:** record each step separately, not just the whole task.
- **Individualize:** steps may be smaller for some clients.

Key words

steps | sequence | chain | % independent

Exam traps

- A task analysis is a LIST of steps, not a teaching method by itself
- Data is recorded for each step
- Chaining is the method used to teach the task analysis

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CARD 48 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Forward and Backward Chaining

Teach the steps starting from the **first** or the **last**.



What it is

Forward chaining: teach the **first step** first; once mastered, add the next step.

Backward chaining: the adult completes all steps except the **last**, which the client does and immediately contacts the reinforcer. Then teach the second-to-last, and so on.

Compare

→ Forward

Starts at step 1. Adds steps in order.

← Backward

Starts at the last step. Reinforcement comes right after.

Tell the difference

Does the client complete the LAST step first while you do the rest?

YES — Backward chaining
Finishing the task = natural reinforcement.

NO — Forward chaining
If teaching starts with the first step.

Step by step

1. **Task analysis** — Steps in order.
2. **Choose method** — As written in the plan.
3. **Teach target step** — First (forward) or last (backward).
4. **Reinforce** — After the target step.
5. **Master** — Meets criterion.
6. **Add a step** — Next one forward or backward.

On the job

- **Backward example:** zipping a jacket: you do everything, client pulls the zipper the last inch.
- **Forward example:** client puts the toothpaste on; you complete the rest; next, they also brush.

Key words

forward | backward | last step | chain | task analysis

Exam traps

- Backward chaining starts with the LAST step
- In backward chaining the client always finishes the task
- Each step must be mastered before adding the next

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CARD 49 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Total Task Chaining

Teach **all steps** every time the task is done.



What it is

In **total task chaining**, the client does **every step** of the task analysis in each session, with prompts on the steps they can't do yet.

It's useful when the client already knows some steps or the task is not too long.

Three chaining methods

→ Forward
First step first.

← Backward
Last step first.

↔ Total task
All steps, every time.

Tell the difference

Does the client go through ALL steps every time, with help where needed?

YES — Total task chaining
Prompt only the steps not yet mastered.

NO — Forward or backward
If only one step is taught at a time.

Step by step

1. **Start the task** — Client begins at step 1.
2. **Do known steps** — Independently.
3. **Prompt** — Only on steps not yet mastered.
4. **Continue** — Through every step.
5. **Reinforce** — At the end of the chain.
6. **Record** — Each step's prompt level.

On the job

- **Example:** making a sandwich: client does every step daily; you prompt only spreading.
- **Good for:** clients who already know many steps.

Key words

all steps | chain | prompt as needed | task analysis

Exam traps

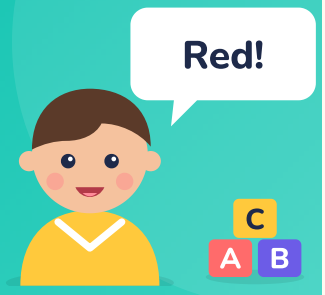
- Total task = every step in every session
- Prompts are faded step by step
- Reinforcement is usually delivered after the whole chain

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CARD 50 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Discrimination Training

Teach the client to respond to the **right cue**.



What it is

Discrimination training reinforces a response in the presence of one stimulus (**SD**) and not in the presence of another (**S-delta**).

When the client reliably responds only to the SD, the behavior is under **stimulus control**.

SD vs S-delta

SD
Reinforcement available
"Touch red" with red card → touching red is reinforced.

SΔ
Not available
Touching the blue card is not reinforced.

Tell the difference

Is reinforcement available for the response when this stimulus is present?

YES **SD**
The response will be reinforced.

NO **S-delta**
The response will not be reinforced.

Step by step

1. **Present the SD**
   With distractors (S-deltas).
2. **Correct response**
   Reinforce.
3. **Incorrect**
   No reinforcement; correction per plan.
4. **Rotate positions**
   Avoid position cues.
5. **Mix targets**
   Randomize which item is the SD.
6. **Check control**
   Responds correctly across trials.

On the job

- **Everyday:** phone ringing (SD) → answering is reinforced; no ring (SΔ) → no one there.
- **Data:** accurate data shows when stimulus control is reached.

Key words

SD | S-delta | stimulus control | discrimination

Exam traps

- SD signals reinforcement is AVAILABLE; S-delta signals it is NOT
- Stimulus control = responds differently to SD and S-delta
- Same position every trial teaches location, not the item

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CARD 51 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Generalization

Use the skill with **new people, places and materials**.



What it is

Stimulus generalization: the skill happens in new conditions (different people, settings, materials).

Response generalization: the client uses a new but similar response (says "hi" or "hello" after learning "hi").

Generalize across

People
Mom, teacher, other RBTs.

Settings
Home, school, park.

Materials
Different pictures and real objects.

Tell the difference

Does the client use the skill outside the teaching situation?

YES Generalized
Skill appears in new conditions.

NO Not yet
Program for generalization with your supervisor.

Promoting generalization

1. **Multiple examples** — Teach with many different items.
2. **Vary people** — Different adults run the program.
3. **Vary settings** — Practice in different rooms or places.
4. **Loose teaching** — Vary wording and materials.
5. **Natural reinforcers** — Use the real-life consequence.
6. **Probe** — Test in a new setting.

On the job

- **Example:** learned "car" with one picture; now labels toy cars, real cars and drawings.
- **Your role:** follow the generalization plan and report what you see in other settings.

Key words

stimulus generalization | response generalization | multiple exemplars | probe

Exam traps

- Generalization must be planned; it doesn't happen automatically
- Teaching with one picture only limits generalization
- New setting = stimulus generalization; new response = response generalization

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CARD 52 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Maintenance

Keep the skill **over time**, after teaching ends.



What it is

Maintenance means the client continues to perform a skill **over time**, even after formal teaching stops.

Skills that are not practiced can be lost, so maintenance is planned.

Generalization vs maintenance

WHERE
Generalization
Across people, places, materials.

WHEN
Maintenance
Over time, after teaching ends.

Tell the difference

Is the client still using a skill learned months ago?

YES Maintained
Keep occasional practice.

NO Not maintained
Report it: booster teaching may be needed.

Promoting maintenance

1. **Thin reinforcement** — Move to intermittent schedules.
2. **Natural reinforcers** — Real-life consequences.
3. **Mix in** — Intersperse mastered targets in sessions.
4. **Probe** — Check mastered skills regularly.
5. **Booster** — Reteach if the skill drops.
6. **Involve caregivers** — Practice in daily life.

On the job

- **Example:** colors mastered in March, probed again in June: still 100%.
- **Interspersal:** mixing mastered and new targets keeps old skills sharp.

Key words

maintenance | probe | booster | intermittent | over time

Exam traps

- Maintenance = over TIME; generalization = across conditions
- Mastered skills should be probed periodically
- Intermittent reinforcement helps maintenance

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CARD 53 | BEHAVIOR ACQUISITION • 25%

Motivating Operations

Why a reinforcer is worth more or less **right now**.



What it is

A **motivating operation (MO)** changes how valuable a reinforcer is at a given moment, and changes how often behavior that gets it happens.

Deprivation makes a reinforcer stronger. **Satiation** makes it weaker.

Two types

EO ↑
Establishing operation

Increases value. Ex.: no water all morning → water is very valuable.

AO ↓
Abolishing operation

Decreases value. Ex.: just ate 10 crackers → crackers lose value.

Tell the difference

Has the client had little or no access to this item recently?

DEPRIVED **Establishing operation (EO)**

Value goes up: more motivation.

SATIATED **Possible abolishing operation**

Lots of access recently: value goes down.

Using MOs in sessions

1. **Check access** — When did the client last have it?
2. **Limit access** — Keep powerful items for sessions.
3. **Small amounts** — Tiny bites or short play times.
4. **Rotate** — Switch reinforcers to avoid satiation.
5. **Watch signs** — Losing interest = possible satiation.
6. **Use mands** — Strong MOs are great moments to teach requests.

On the job

- **Example:** client had tablet all morning at home → tablet may not work as a reinforcer today.
- **Teaching:** an EO makes the client more likely to mand for the item.

Key words

deprivation | satiation | EO | AO | value

Exam traps

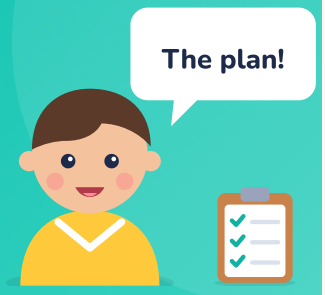
- EO increases value; AO decreases value
- MOs are about the value of the reinforcer, not the SD
- Giving large amounts of a reinforcer can create satiation

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CARD 54 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Behavior Intervention Plans (BIP)

The written plan for problem behavior, and **the RBT's role**.



What it is

A **behavior intervention plan (BIP)** is written by the BCBA, based on the function of the behavior. It explains how to **prevent**, **replace** and **respond to** problem behavior.

The RBT implements the plan **exactly as written** and collects data.

What a BIP includes

- Operational definition of the behavior
- Hypothesized function
- Antecedent (prevention) strategies
- Replacement behaviors to teach
- Consequence strategies
- Crisis / safety plan

Tell the difference

Do you think a part of the plan isn't working?

NOT WORKING **Tell your supervisor**
Share your data and observations; keep following the plan.

WORKING **Keep implementing**
Consistently, exactly as written.

Implementing a BIP

1. **Read the plan** — Before working with the client.
2. **Ask questions** — Clarify anything unclear.
3. **Prevent** — Use the antecedent strategies.
4. **Teach** — Prompt and reinforce replacement behaviors.
5. **Respond** — Follow the consequence steps.
6. **Record** — Data every session.

On the job

- **Consistency:** every adult responds the same way; inconsistency can make behavior worse.
- **Treatment integrity:** following the plan exactly is called treatment (procedural) fidelity.

Key words

BIP | fidelity | replacement | function | consistency

Exam traps

- The RBT never changes the BIP on their own
- The plan is based on the FUNCTION, not on what the behavior looks like
- Report concerns, but continue the plan until the supervisor changes it

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CARD 55 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Antecedent Interventions

Change what happens **before** so the behavior is **less likely**.



What it is

Antecedent interventions change the environment or situation **before** problem behavior happens, to prevent it.

They often work by reducing the motivation for the problem behavior or by making the right behavior easier.

Common strategies

- **Visual schedules:** show what comes next
- **Choices:** "red or blue pencil?"
- **Priming:** preview a change in advance
- **Task changes:** shorter or easier tasks
- **NCR:** reinforcement on a time schedule
- **High-p sequence:** easy requests first

Tell the difference

Is the strategy used BEFORE the behavior happens?

BEFORE Antecedent intervention
Prevention.

AFTER Consequence strategy
If it is used after the behavior.

Using antecedent strategies

1. **Know the triggers** — From the BIP and ABC data.
2. **Set up** — Arrange the environment as planned.
3. **Preview** — Tell the client what's coming.
4. **Offer choices** — When the plan allows.
5. **Adjust demands** — As written in the plan.
6. **Record** — Note what was used and the result.

On the job

- **Example:** transitions trigger tantrums: show the visual schedule and give a 2-minute warning.
- **Proactive:** prevention is usually easier than responding to behavior.

Key words

prevention | trigger | visual schedule | choice | priming

Exam traps

- Antecedent = before; consequence = after
- Antecedent strategies don't teach a new skill by themselves
- Use only strategies included in the plan

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CARD 56 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Noncontingent Reinforcement

Give the reinforcer **on a timer**, not after the behavior.



What it is

Noncontingent reinforcement (NCR) delivers the reinforcer that maintains a behavior on a **time schedule**, regardless of the behavior.

Because the client already gets it freely, the **motivation** to do the problem behavior goes down.

Contingent vs noncontingent

Contingent
After behavior

Attention given because the client yelled.

NCR
By the clock

Attention given every 2 minutes, no matter what.

Tell the difference

Is the reinforcer delivered based on TIME, not on what the client just did?

TIME **NCR**
Fixed or variable time schedule.

BEHAVIOR **Contingent reinforcement**
Delivered after a specific behavior.

Step by step

1. **Know the function**
   E.g., attention.
2. **Set the timer**
   Interval from the plan (e.g., 2 min).
3. **Deliver**
   When the timer goes off.
4. **Regardless**
   Even if behavior just happened, per plan.
5. **Thin**
   Make the interval longer over time, as planned.
6. **Record**
   Behavior during NCR.

On the job

- **Attention:** every 2 min: brief praise and interaction.
- **Tangible:** toy given every 5 min for 1 min.
- **Why it works:** it's an antecedent strategy: it reduces the MO.

Key words

fixed time | noncontingent | MO | thinning | antecedent

Exam traps

- NCR is delivered by TIME, not after a behavior
- NCR is an antecedent intervention
- The schedule is thinned only as the plan says

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CARD 57 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

High-Probability Request Sequence

Easy requests first build **momentum** for the hard one.



What it is

In a **high-p request sequence**, you give 3 to 5 quick, easy requests the client is **very likely to follow**, reinforce each, then give the **low-p** (harder) request.

This is also called **behavioral momentum**.

High-p vs low-p

High-p
Easy
"High five", "touch nose", "clap".

Low-p
Hard
"Start your worksheet."

Tell the difference

Do the easy requests come RIGHT BEFORE the harder one?

YES **High-p sequence**
Momentum carries into the low-p request.

NO **Not a high-p sequence**
Spacing or order is off.

Step by step

1. **Pick high-p** — Requests the client almost always follows.
2. **Deliver fast** — One after another.
3. **Reinforce each** — Brief praise.
4. **Then low-p** — Right after the last high-p.
5. **Reinforce** — Compliance with the low-p request.
6. **Record** — Did the client comply?

On the job

- **Example:** "High five!" "Touch your head!" "Clap!" → "Now put your shoes on."
- **Fit:** often used for escape-maintained behavior and noncompliance.

Key words

momentum | high-p | low-p | compliance

Exam traps

- High-p requests come IMMEDIATELY before the low-p request
- Each high-p response is reinforced
- High-p requests must be truly easy for that client

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CARD 58 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Extinction

Stop delivering the reinforcer that **kept the behavior going**.



What it is

Extinction means the reinforcer that previously maintained a behavior is **no longer delivered** after that behavior.

Over time, the behavior decreases. How extinction looks depends on the **function**.

By function

Attention
Planned ignoring

No reaction to the behavior.

Escape
Escape extinction

The task continues; no break for the behavior.

Tangible
No access

The item is not given for the behavior.

Tell the difference

Does the procedure withhold the SAME reinforcer that maintains the behavior?

YES **Extinction**
Matches the function.

NO **Not extinction**
E.g., ignoring escape-maintained behavior won't work.

Using extinction

1. **Know the function**
   From the BIP.
2. **Withhold**
   That specific reinforcer, every time.
3. **Stay consistent**
   Everyone, everywhere, every time.
4. **Expect a burst**
   It may get worse first.
5. **Reinforce alternatives**
   Usually combined with DRA or FCT.
6. **Record**
   Track changes carefully.

On the job

- **Example:** attention-maintained whining: no eye contact or comments for whining; attention for asking nicely.
- **Safety:** some behaviors can't be ignored; follow the plan's safety steps.

Key words

withhold | function | planned ignoring | consistency | burst

Exam traps

- Ignoring is extinction ONLY for attention-maintained behavior
- Inconsistent extinction turns into intermittent reinforcement
- Extinction is not punishment: nothing is added or removed as a penalty

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CARD 59 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Extinction Burst

When extinction starts, behavior often gets **worse before better**.



What it is

An **extinction burst** is a temporary increase in the **frequency, intensity or duration** of a behavior right after extinction begins.

New behaviors may also appear. It means the reinforcer is truly being withheld.

What to expect

Burst
More, louder or longer behavior at first.

Then
If extinction is consistent, the behavior decreases.

Tell the difference

Did the behavior suddenly get worse right after extinction started?

WORSE **Likely extinction burst**
Stay consistent and follow the plan.

NO CHANGE **Keep monitoring**
Record and report as usual.

Getting through a burst

1. **Expect it** — The plan should warn you.
2. **Stay calm** — Neutral face and voice.
3. **Don't give in** — Giving the reinforcer now teaches a bigger behavior.
4. **Keep safe** — Follow safety steps if needed.
5. **Record** — Burst data matters.
6. **Report** — Tell your supervisor.

On the job

- **Example:** a child who used to get candy for crying cries louder and longer for 2 days, then crying drops.
- **Vending machine:** you press the button harder when nothing comes out: a burst.

Key words

burst | intensity | temporary | consistency

Exam traps

- A burst is expected and temporary, not a sign of failure
- Giving in during a burst reinforces a more intense behavior
- New problem behaviors can appear during a burst

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Spontaneous Recovery

An extinguished behavior **comes back** for a short time.



What it is

Spontaneous recovery is when a behavior that decreased during extinction **suddenly reappears** after some time.

If the behavior is still not reinforced, it usually fades again quickly.

Burst vs recovery

Burst
At the start
Increase right after extinction begins.

Recovery
Later
Returns after the behavior had already dropped.

Tell the difference

Had the behavior already decreased before it came back?

ALREADY LOW **Spontaneous recovery**
Keep the extinction procedure going.

JUST STARTED **Possible burst**
If extinction just started.

What to do

1. **Don't panic**
   It's a normal part of extinction.
2. **Stay consistent**
   Withhold the reinforcer.
3. **Reinforce alternatives**
   Keep teaching the replacement.
4. **Record**
   Note when it reappeared.
5. **Report**
   Let your supervisor know.
6. **Watch**
   It should fade again.

On the job

- **Example:** tantrums stopped for 2 weeks, then one appears after a long weekend.
- **Risk:** reinforcing it now can bring the behavior back strongly.

Key words

reappear | extinction | consistency | after a break

Exam traps

- Spontaneous recovery happens AFTER the behavior had decreased
- Keep extinction in place; don't reinforce the returning behavior
- Burst = beginning; recovery = later

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CARD 61 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

DRA

Differential reinforcement of an **Alternative** behavior.



What it is

In **DRA**, you reinforce an **appropriate alternative behavior** and withhold reinforcement for the problem behavior.

The alternative usually gets the client the **same reinforcer** (same function).

Before → after

✗ **Problem**
Screams to get a toy → no toy.

✓ **Alternative**
Says "toy please" → gets the toy.

Tell the difference

Is a specific, appropriate behavior being reinforced instead of the problem?

YES DRA
Reinforce the alternative; extinction for the problem.

NO Check DRO
If you reinforce simply the ABSENCE of the problem behavior.

Step by step

1. **Know the function**
   What the behavior gets.
2. **Pick the alternative**
   From the plan.
3. **Prompt it**
   Help the client use it.
4. **Reinforce fast**
   Every time at first.
5. **Withhold**
   No reinforcer for the problem behavior.
6. **Fade prompts**
   Toward independence.

On the job

- **Example:** client hits to get attention → taught to tap your shoulder; tapping gets attention, hitting doesn't.
- **Can coexist:** the alternative doesn't have to be physically impossible to do with the problem.

Key words

alternative | same function | replacement | extinction

Exam traps

- DRA reinforces a SPECIFIC appropriate behavior
- The alternative can happen at the same time as the problem (unlike DRI)
- FCT is a type of DRA using communication

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CARD 62 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

DRO

Differential reinforcement of **Other** behavior: reinforce **its absence**.



What it is

In **DRO**, the client earns reinforcement when the problem behavior **does not occur** for a set interval.

If the behavior happens, the interval usually **resets**.

How DRO works

✓ **5 min, no hitting**
Earns reinforcement.

↺ **Hit at min 3**
Timer resets; no reinforcement yet.

Tell the difference

Is reinforcement earned simply because the problem behavior did NOT happen?

YES **DRO**
Absence of the behavior for the interval.

NO **DRA or DRI**
If a specific behavior is required.

Step by step

1. **Set the interval**
   From the plan (e.g., 5 min).
2. **Start timer**
   Watch for the behavior.
3. **No behavior?**
   Reinforce at the end of the interval.
4. **Behavior occurs**
   Reset the timer, per plan.
5. **Lengthen**
   Increase the interval as planned.
6. **Record**
   Intervals earned.

On the job

- **Example:** every 10 min without spitting earns 2 min of a preferred video.
- **Watch out:** the client may do another problem behavior at the moment of reinforcement.

Key words

omission | absence | interval | reset

Exam traps

- DRO reinforces the ABSENCE of the problem behavior
- Interval resets when the behavior occurs (in most DRO plans)
- DRO does not teach a specific replacement behavior

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CARD 63 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

DRI

Differential reinforcement of an **Incompatible** behavior.



What it is

In **DRI**, you reinforce a behavior that **cannot physically happen at the same time** as the problem behavior.

If the client is doing the incompatible behavior, the problem behavior is impossible.

Incompatible pairs

Hands in lap vs hitting
Can't do both.

Walking vs running
Can't do both.

Mouth closed vs spitting
Can't do both.

Tell the difference

Is it physically IMPOSSIBLE to do both behaviors at once?

IMPOSSIBLE → DRI
Reinforce the incompatible behavior.

POSSIBLE → DRA
If both could happen together.

Step by step

1. **Problem behavior**
   E.g., putting objects in mouth.
2. **Choose incompatible**
   E.g., hands busy holding a fidget.
3. **Prompt it**
   Help the client start it.
4. **Reinforce**
   While the client does it.
5. **Withhold**
   No reinforcement for the problem.
6. **Record**
   Track both behaviors.

On the job

- **Example:** reinforce sitting in seat to reduce running around the classroom.
- **Tip:** on the exam, ask: could the client do both at the same time?

Key words

incompatible | physically impossible | replacement

Exam traps

- DRI: the two behaviors cannot occur at the same time
- If both CAN happen together, it's DRA
- DRI still requires withholding reinforcement for the problem behavior

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CARD 64 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

DRL

Differential reinforcement of **Lower** rates of behavior.



What it is

In **DRL**, reinforcement is given when a behavior happens **less often** than a set limit.

It is used for behaviors that are OK in small amounts but a problem when they happen **too often**.

Too much vs just right

✗
15 times
Raises hand 15 times in class.

✓
3 or fewer
Raises hand 3 times or less → earns reinforcement.

Tell the difference

Is the goal to REDUCE a behavior that is fine in moderation, not eliminate it?

REDUCE **DRL**
Reinforce lower rates.

ELIMINATE **Other procedures**
DRO, DRA or extinction to eliminate it.

Step by step

1. **Baseline** — How often does it happen now?
2. **Set the limit** — From the plan.
3. **Count** — During the session.
4. **At or below?** — Reinforce.
5. **Above?** — No reinforcement for that period.
6. **Lower gradually** — As the plan directs.

On the job

- **Example:** asking the same question many times: reinforce if asked 2 times or fewer per hour.
- **Key idea:** the behavior is still allowed, just less often.

Key words

lower rate | limit | moderation | reduce

Exam traps

- DRL reduces, it does NOT eliminate the behavior
- Used for behaviors acceptable at low rates
- DRO = absence; DRL = fewer times

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CARD 65 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Functional Communication Training (FCT)

Teach a way to **ask** for what the problem behavior used to get.



What it is

FCT teaches a **communication response** that gets the same reinforcer as the problem behavior (same function).

It is a type of **DRA**. The communication can be words, signs, pictures or a device.

Same function, new way

✗ **Before**

Throws materials → work stops (escape).

✓ **After**

Says or signs "break" → work stops for a short time.

Tell the difference

Does the new communication get the client the SAME thing the problem behavior did?

YES **FCT**

Matches the function.

NO **Not FCT**

Teaching a response with a different function won't replace the behavior.

Step by step

1. **Know the function**
   Attention, escape or tangible.
2. **Choose the response**
   Easy to do and understood by others.
3. **Prompt it**
   Before the problem behavior happens.
4. **Reinforce right away**
   Every time at first.
5. **Extinction**
   No reinforcer for the problem behavior.
6. **Thin over time**
   Delays, as the plan says.

On the job

- **Attention:** teach "look at me" or a tap on the shoulder.
- **Tangible:** teach "can I have ___?"
- **Escape:** teach "break" or "help".

Key words

communication | function | mand | replacement | DRA

Exam traps

- FCT = DRA using communication
- The new response must match the FUNCTION of the problem behavior
- Respond quickly to the new communication, especially at first

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CARD 66 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Positive vs Negative Punishment

Both **decrease** behavior: one **adds**, one **removes**.



What it is

Punishment is a consequence that makes a behavior **less likely** in the future.

Positive punishment adds something; **negative punishment** removes something the client likes.

Add or remove?

+ ↓ Positive punishment
Something added → behavior decreases. Ex.: reprimand.

− ↓ Negative punishment
Something removed → behavior decreases. Ex.: loses tablet time.

Tell the difference

After the behavior, was something ADDED or REMOVED (and the behavior decreased)?

ADDED **Positive punishment**
A stimulus was added.

REMOVED **Negative punishment**
A preferred stimulus was taken away.

Identify it

1. **Behavior** — Find the target behavior.
2. **Consequence** — What happened right after?
3. **Future** — Did the behavior decrease?
4. **Added?** — Positive punishment.
5. **Removed?** — Negative punishment.
6. **Plan only** — Used only if written in the BIP.

On the job

- **Reinforcement first:** ethical ABA uses reinforcement-based strategies first.
- **Response cost and time-out:** are forms of negative punishment.

Key words

decrease | add | remove | least restrictive

Exam traps

- Punishment is defined by its EFFECT: behavior decreases
- Negative punishment ≠ negative reinforcement
- The RBT uses punishment only if the BCBA's plan includes it

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CARD 67 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Response Cost

Lose a **set amount** of a reinforcer after the behavior.



What it is

Response cost removes a **specific amount** of a reinforcer (such as tokens or points) after a problem behavior.

It is a form of **negative punishment**, often used within a token economy.

Example

5
tokens earned
For completing tasks.

−1
after cursing
One token removed, as written in the plan.

Tell the difference

Is a specific amount of a reinforcer taken away after the behavior?

YES Response cost
Negative punishment.

NO Check time-out
If access to all reinforcement is removed for a period.

Step by step

1. **Rules first**
   The client knows which behaviors cost tokens.
2. **Behavior occurs**
   As defined.
3. **Remove**
   The exact amount stated in the plan.
4. **Stay neutral**
   Calm tone, no lecture.
5. **Keep earning**
   The client can still earn tokens.
6. **Record**
   Each response cost.

On the job

- **Balance:** the client should earn far more than they lose.
- **Avoid:** removing all tokens can lead to giving up or more problem behavior.

Key words

fine | tokens | negative punishment | neutral

Exam traps

- Response cost = losing a specific amount of reinforcer
- It is negative punishment, not negative reinforcement
- Use only if it is part of the BCBA's plan

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CARD 68 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Time-Out from Reinforcement

Remove **access to reinforcement** for a short time.



What it is

Time-out removes the client's access to reinforcement for a short period after a problem behavior. It is **negative punishment**.

Non-exclusionary: the client stays in the room.
Exclusionary: the client is moved away from the activity.

Two types

Stays
Non-exclusionary

Stays in place but reinforcement stops (e.g., toy put away).

Moves
Exclusionary

Leaves the area for a short time.

Tell the difference

Is the behavior maintained by ESCAPE from the activity?

ESCAPE **Time-out may reinforce it**

Leaving the task could be what the client wants.

OTHER **Time-out may be in the plan**

For attention or tangible functions, as decided by the BCBA.

Step by step

1. **Plan required** — Only if the BIP includes it.
2. **Behavior occurs** — As defined.
3. **Calm statement** — Brief, neutral.
4. **Time-out** — For the exact duration in the plan.
5. **Return** — Back to the activity.
6. **Record** — Duration and behavior.

On the job

- **Time-in:** time-out only works if the activity ("time-in") is reinforcing.
- **Safety:** follow all agency policies; never lock a client in a room.

Key words

time-out | exclusionary | non-exclusionary | time-in

Exam traps

- Time-out can REINFORCE escape-maintained behavior
- Time-out is negative punishment
- Only use it exactly as written in the plan

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CARD 69 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Escape-Maintained Behavior

The behavior helps the client **get out** of something.



What it is

Escape-maintained behavior is reinforced by ending or avoiding something unpleasant: a task, a demand, a noise, a situation.

It is maintained by **negative reinforcement**.

Common strategies

- **Prevent:** easier or shorter tasks, choices, high-p sequence
- **Teach:** ask for a break or help (FCT)
- **Respond:** escape extinction (task continues), if in the plan
- **Reinforce:** compliance and work completed

Tell the difference

Does the problem behavior end or delay a task or demand?

YES — Likely escape function
Follow the escape plan in the BIP.

NO — Check other functions
Attention, tangible or automatic.

Step by step

1. **Prevent**
   Use antecedent strategies.
2. **Prompt the request**
   "Say break" before behavior escalates.
3. **Honor requests**
   Give the break when asked appropriately.
4. **Follow through**
   Don't remove the task after problem behavior.
5. **Reinforce work**
   Praise and reinforcers for compliance.
6. **Record**
   Data every session.

On the job

- **Example:** client tears worksheet → in the plan, the task stays; asking "break please" earns a 2-min break.
- **Trap:** sending the client away after problem behavior gives them what they wanted.

Key words

escape | avoidance | negative reinforcement | break | follow-through

Exam traps

- Removing the task after problem behavior reinforces escape
- Escape = negative reinforcement
- Time-out may worsen escape-maintained behavior

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CARD 70 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Attention-Maintained Behavior

The behavior gets **a reaction** from other people.



What it is

Attention-maintained behavior is reinforced by others' attention: looking, talking, scolding, laughing, even reprimands.

It is maintained by **positive reinforcement**.

Common strategies

- **Prevent:** frequent attention on a schedule (NCR)
- **Teach:** appropriate ways to get attention (FCT)
- **Respond:** planned ignoring of the problem behavior, if in the plan
- **Reinforce:** give attention for appropriate behavior

Tell the difference

Does the behavior usually happen when adults are busy or not paying attention?

YES **Likely attention function**
Follow the attention plan in the BIP.

NO **Check other functions**
Escape, tangible or automatic.

Step by step

1. **Give attention often**
   Catch the client being good.
2. **Teach the ask**
   "Look at me", tap, raise hand.
3. **Respond to the ask**
   Quickly at first.
4. **Planned ignoring**
   Minimal reaction to the problem, if safe and in the plan.
5. **Stay consistent**
   Everyone responds the same.
6. **Record**
   Data every session.

On the job

- **Example:** client throws toys when parent is on the phone → teach tapping arm; parent responds to taps.
- **Trap:** scolding is attention too: it can reinforce the behavior.

Key words

attention | planned ignoring | NCR | positive reinforcement

Exam traps

- Reprimands can reinforce attention-maintained behavior
- Planned ignoring is extinction for attention, not for escape
- Give attention for appropriate behavior, not only after problems

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CARD 71 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Automatically Maintained Behavior

The behavior produces **its own** reinforcement.



What it is

Automatically maintained (sensory) behavior is reinforced by the sensation it produces, not by other people.

It often continues when the client is alone. Examples: rocking, hand flapping, humming, skin picking.

Common strategies

- **Enrich:** provide engaging activities and items
- **Match the sensation:** an appropriate item with similar input
- **Redirect:** to an alternative activity, as planned
- **Reinforce:** other behaviors (DRA / DRO), as planned

Tell the difference

Does the behavior happen even when the client is alone, with nothing to gain from others?

YES — Possible automatic function
The BCBA confirms with data.

NO — Likely social function
Attention, escape or tangible.

Step by step

1. **Observe** — When and where does it happen?
2. **Record** — Including when the client is alone.
3. **Enrich** — Offer the planned activities.
4. **Redirect** — As written in the plan.
5. **Reinforce** — Alternative behaviors.
6. **Report** — Changes or safety concerns.

On the job

- **Example:** client hums loudly during independent work → given headphones with music (matched stimulation), as planned.
- **Harmful?:** only behaviors that interfere or cause harm are targeted, per the BCBA.

Key words

automatic | sensory | matched stimulation | enrichment

Exam traps

- Automatic reinforcement doesn't depend on other people
- Ignoring usually doesn't work for automatic behavior
- Decisions to reduce sensory behavior are made by the BCBA

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CARD 72 | BEHAVIOR REDUCTION • 19%

Crisis and Emergency Procedures

When safety is at risk: **follow the crisis plan**.



What it is

A **crisis plan** describes what to do when behavior puts the client or others at risk of harm.

The RBT uses **only the procedures they are trained and authorized** to use, following agency policy.

Core rules

- Keep everyone safe first
- Stay calm: low, neutral voice
- Give space; remove dangerous items
- Use only approved, trained procedures
- Get help when needed
- Document and notify your supervisor

Tell the difference

Is anyone at immediate risk of harm?

RISK — Follow the crisis plan
Safety procedures as trained.

NO RISK — Follow the BIP
Regular strategies for the behavior.

During a crisis

1. **Assess** — Is anyone in danger?
2. **Protect** — Move others away, remove objects.
3. **De-escalate** — Calm voice, few words, space.
4. **Use approved steps** — Only those in the plan and your training.
5. **Call for help** — Per agency procedure.
6. **Report** — Incident report + supervisor right away.

On the job

- **Restraint:** only if part of the plan, agency policy and your certified training.
- **Afterwards:** complete documentation the same day, as your agency requires.

Key words

safety | de-escalation | crisis plan | incident report

Exam traps

- Never use a procedure you haven't been trained and authorized to use
- Safety comes before teaching goals
- Every crisis must be documented and reported to the supervisor

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CARD 73 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Session Notes: Why They Matter

The official **record** of every session.



What it is

A **session note** documents what happened in each session: what was worked on, how the client responded and anything important that occurred.

Notes are **clinical and legal records**. They are also used for **billing** and for the next staff member to continue care.

Why notes matter

- Shows the services provided
- Supports insurance billing
- Lets the team track progress
- Helps other staff continue care
- Protects the client, you and the agency

Tell the difference

Could another professional understand exactly what happened from your note?

YES Good note
Clear, objective and complete.

NO Rewrite it
Add specifics; remove vague or emotional language.

A good note is

1. **Same day** — Write it within your agency's deadline.
2. **Objective** — Facts, not opinions.
3. **Specific** — Targets, data, times.
4. **Complete** — All required fields.
5. **Accurate** — Only what really happened.
6. **Sign** — As your agency requires.

On the job

- **Example:** "Worked on 4 mand targets; 18/20 independent. 2 episodes of crying (≈1 min each) during transitions."
- **Avoid:** "Great session!" or "He was in a bad mood."

Key words

clinical record | billing | objective | continuity of care

Exam traps

- Session notes are legal documents
- Never write a note for a session that didn't happen as described
- Opinions and feelings don't belong in notes

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CARD 74 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

What Goes in a Session Note

The **checklist** for a complete note.



What it is

Each agency has its own template, but most session notes include the same core information.

Missing information can cause **billing problems** and make it hard for the team to use the note.

Core content

- Date, start and end times
- Location and people present
- Targets and programs worked on
- Data summary (e.g., % correct)
- Behaviors that occurred and how you responded
- Notable events, client's condition

Tell the difference

Did anything unusual happen (injury, illness, new behavior)?

YES **Document it and tell your supervisor**
Plus incident report if required.

NO **Standard note**
Complete all usual fields.

Writing it in order

1. **Header**
   Client, date, times, setting.
2. **Who was there**
   Caregivers, siblings, staff.
3. **What you did**
   Programs, procedures used.
4. **Results**
   Data, not impressions.
5. **Behavior**
   What happened and how you responded.
6. **Sign**
   Name and credential.

On the job

- **Times:** write the exact start and end times; they must match billing.
- **Condition:** "Client reported a headache" is useful information to note.

Key words

date | time in/out | targets | data | signature

Exam traps

- Times in the note must match the actual session
- Leave out other clients' names and private details
- Use your agency's template and required fields

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CARD 75 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Objective vs Subjective Language

Write what a **camera** could record.



What it is

Objective language describes observable facts: actions, words, counts, times.

Subjective language includes opinions, feelings, labels and guesses about intent. It is avoided in documentation.

Rewrite it

✗ **Subjective**

"She was being difficult and wanted attention."

✓ **Objective**

"She said 'no' to 4 of 6 instructions and sat on the floor for 2 min."

Tell the difference

Does your sentence include feelings, labels or a guess about WHY?

YES **Subjective**
Rewrite with observable facts.

NO **Objective**
Good documentation.

Turn subjective into objective

1. **Find the label** — Angry, lazy, defiant, happy.
2. **Ask** — What did I actually see or hear?
3. **Describe actions** — Words, movements, sounds.
4. **Add numbers** — How many, how long.
5. **Add context** — When and during what activity.
6. **Re-read** — Could anyone verify it?

On the job

- **"Had a meltdown":** → "cried and kicked the floor for 5 min after the tablet was removed."
- **"Was happy":** → "smiled and laughed during the bubbles activity."

Key words

observable | measurable | specific | verifiable

Exam traps

- "He wanted attention" is a guess, not an observation
- Labels like defiant, lazy or aggressive are subjective
- The most specific, measurable description is the correct answer

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CARD 76 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

When to Contact Your Supervisor

Some situations need your supervisor **right away**.



What it is

The RBT works under close supervision. Communicating promptly with the supervisor is part of the job and of the **RBT Ethics Code**.

When something is outside your role or you are unsure, **ask before acting**.

Contact your supervisor when

- Safety concern, injury or crisis
- New or more intense problem behavior
- Plan doesn't seem to work or is unclear
- Client illness, medication or major life change
- Caregiver concerns or requests to change treatment
- Possible ethics issue

Tell the difference

Is the issue outside what your plan or training covers?

YES **Contact your supervisor**
Before taking action.

NO **Follow the plan**
And document as usual.

Step by step

1. **Safety first** — Handle immediate safety per the crisis plan.
2. **Contact** — Using the agency's channel.
3. **Be objective** — Describe what happened, with data.
4. **Ask** — For clear direction.
5. **Follow** — The direction given.
6. **Document** — The contact and guidance.

On the job

- **Example:** a parent asks you to stop using the token board → explain you'll check with the supervisor.
- **Timing:** urgent issues right away; routine questions at the next supervision.

Key words

supervisor | clinical direction | prompt communication | document

Exam traps

- Don't change programs because a caregiver asked; contact the supervisor
- Report new or worsening behaviors promptly
- Unsure? Ask before acting

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CARD 77 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Variables That Affect the Client

Sleep, illness, meds and changes can **change behavior**.



What it is

Many things outside the session can affect how a client behaves and learns. These are sometimes called **setting events**.

Noticing and reporting them helps the supervisor **interpret the data** correctly.

Common variables

- Sleep (too little, poor quality)
- Illness, pain, allergies
- Medication changes
- Hunger, diet changes
- Family changes (move, new sibling, divorce)
- Schedule or staff changes

Tell the difference

Did something unusual happen before the session that could affect behavior?

YES **Note it and tell your supervisor**
It may explain the data.

NO **Run the session as usual**
Record data normally.

Step by step

1. **Ask caregivers** — "How did they sleep?" at the start.
2. **Observe** — Signs of illness or fatigue.
3. **Record facts** — "Mom reported 4 hours of sleep."
4. **Run the plan** — Unless told otherwise.
5. **Report** — To your supervisor.
6. **Watch data** — Does it match the variable?

On the job

- **Example:** client started a new medication on Monday; problem behavior doubled this week → report it.
- **Your role:** report, don't diagnose or comment on medication.

Key words

setting events | sleep | medication | illness | report

Exam traps

- Medication questions go to the client's doctor; report changes to the supervisor
- Write what caregivers reported, not your own conclusion
- Unusual data may come from an outside variable

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CARD 78 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Incident Reports

Document **unusual events** the same day.



What it is

An **incident report** documents unusual or serious events, such as injuries, elopement, property damage or use of a crisis procedure.

Each agency has its own form and deadline. Reports must be **objective, complete and timely**.

Usually reported

- Injury to the client or others
- Elopement (client leaves unsupervised)
- Property damage
- Use of a crisis or restrictive procedure
- Any event your agency requires

Tell the difference

Did a serious or unusual event happen during the session?

YES **Incident report + notify supervisor**
As soon as possible, same day.

NO **Session note**
Regular documentation.

Step by step

1. **Safety first** — Handle the situation per the plan.
2. **Notify** — Supervisor and caregivers as required.
3. **Fill the form** — Agency template.
4. **Facts only** — What, when, where, who, how.
5. **Your response** — What you did and the outcome.
6. **Submit on time** — Within the agency deadline.

On the job

- **Example:** "At 2:15 pm the client ran out the front door; RBT followed and returned with client at 2:17 pm; no injuries."
- **Honesty:** never leave out details to look better.

Key words

incident | objective | timely | elopement | injury

Exam traps

- Incident reports must be objective and submitted on time
- Notify the supervisor; don't decide alone whether to report
- Include what you did in response

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CARD 79 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Mandated Reporting

Suspected **abuse or neglect** must be reported.



What it is

Many RBTs are **mandated reporters**: they must report **suspected** abuse or neglect to the proper authorities, according to their state's law.

You don't need proof. Reporting is based on **reasonable suspicion**.

Key rules

- Report suspicion to the proper authority, as your state law requires
- Also follow your agency's policy and inform your supervisor
- Don't investigate or question the child to collect evidence
- Document objectively what you saw or heard
- Keep it confidential

Tell the difference

Do you have a reasonable suspicion of abuse or neglect?

YES **Report it**
Per state law and agency policy.

NO **Keep observing**
Document anything concerning.

Step by step

1. **Notice**
   Injuries, statements, signs of neglect.
2. **Don't investigate**
   No interrogation or photos unless policy says.
3. **Write facts**
   Exact words and observations.
4. **Report**
   To the authority required by law.
5. **Inform**
   Your supervisor/agency, per policy.
6. **Confidential**
   Don't discuss with others.

On the job

- **Example:** a child says "Dad hits me with a belt" → write exact words, report as required, inform your supervisor.
- **Law varies:** learn the rules for your state and agency.

Key words

mandated reporter | suspicion | abuse | neglect | confidential

Exam traps

- You report SUSPICION; you don't need proof
- Telling only your supervisor may not meet your legal duty: know your state law
- Never investigate or confront the family yourself

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CARD 80 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Confidentiality in Documentation

Protect the client's **private information**.



What it is

Client information is private health information. In the US, it is protected by laws like **HIPAA** and by the RBT Ethics Code.

Share information only with people **authorized** to receive it, and only what they **need**.

Share or not?

✓ **OK**
Supervisor, treatment team, authorized caregivers.

✗ **Not OK**
Friends, social media, other families, unsecured texts.

Tell the difference

Is this person authorized to receive this client's information?

AUTHORIZED **Share only what is needed**
Minimum necessary.

NOT AUTHORIZED **Don't share**
Ask your supervisor if unsure.

Protecting information

1. **Use initials/IDs** — Where your agency allows.
2. **Secure systems** — Approved apps and platforms.
3. **No personal devices** — Unless approved and secured.
4. **Private talks** — Don't discuss clients in public.
5. **Minimum necessary** — Share only what's required.
6. **Report breaches** — Right away to your supervisor.

On the job

- **Example:** another parent asks how a client is doing → "I can't share information about other families."
- **Texts:** don't text client details from your personal phone unless your agency approves it.

Key words

HIPAA | confidential | authorized | minimum necessary | breach

Exam traps

- Never post anything about clients on social media
- Share only with authorized people, only what is needed
- Report any accidental disclosure right away

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CARD 81 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Storing and Transporting Data Securely

Data sheets and devices must be **protected**.



What it is

Paper data sheets and electronic data contain **protected client information**. They must be stored and moved securely.

Follow your agency's policy for storage, transport and disposal.

Paper vs digital

Paper
Locked folder or bag; never left visible in a car.

Digital
Approved, password-protected, encrypted devices and apps.

Tell the difference

Could someone else see or access this client's data?

YES **Secure it now**
Lock, cover or log out.

NO **Stored correctly**
Keep following policy.

Step by step

1. **Collect**
   On approved sheets or apps.
2. **Carry**
   In a closed, secure folder or bag.
3. **Devices**
   Locked screen, passwords.
4. **Never leave**
   Data visible in a car or public place.
5. **Deliver**
   To the agency as required.
6. **Dispose**
   Shred or delete per policy.

On the job

- **Example:** you stop for lunch: data folder goes with you or locked out of sight, per policy.
- **Lost data:** report a lost tablet or folder to your supervisor immediately.

Key words

secure | encrypted | password | locked | dispose

Exam traps

- Leaving data sheets visible in a car is a confidentiality risk
- Lost devices or data must be reported immediately
- Use only agency-approved apps and storage

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CARD 82 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Talking with Caregivers

Be **friendly and professional**, and stay **within your role**.



What it is

Caregivers often ask the RBT questions. You can share **objective information** about the session, as your supervisor allows.

Clinical questions (diagnosis, treatment changes, prognosis) go to the **supervisor**.

Can I answer?

✓ **Within role**

What you worked on today, objective data, upcoming schedule.

→ **BCBA**

Refer

"Should we change the plan?" "Will he talk?" "Is it autism?"

Tell the difference

Is the question about diagnosis, treatment decisions or prognosis?

CLINICAL → **Refer to the supervisor**

"Great question, I'll ask my supervisor."

SESSION INFO → **Answer objectively**

Within what your supervisor allows.

Step by step

1. **Greet** — Be warm and respectful.
2. **Share facts** — What happened in the session.
3. **Listen** — Take note of concerns.
4. **Refer** — Clinical questions to the BCBA.
5. **Follow up** — Tell your supervisor what was asked.
6. **Document** — Important conversations.

On the job

- **Example:** Mom: "Can we stop the token board?" → "I'll pass that to your supervisor today."
- **Avoid:** giving opinions about other providers, medications or diagnoses.

Key words

caregiver | scope | refer | objective | professional

Exam traps

- Clinical recommendations come from the BCBA, not the RBT
- Don't promise outcomes ("he'll be talking by summer")
- Share session information only as your supervisor permits

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CARD 83 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Supervision Requirements

RBTs practice **under ongoing supervision**.



What it is

RBTs must receive **ongoing supervision** from a qualified supervisor while providing behavior-analytic services.

The BACB sets minimum requirements each month, such as a percentage of service hours and real-time contacts that include observation with a client.

What the rules cover

- **A minimum % of service hours supervised each month**
- **Real-time contacts with the supervisor each month**
- **At least some contacts observe you working with a client**
- **Supervision is documented**

Check the current RBT Handbook at bacb.com for the exact numbers.

Tell the difference

Are you providing services without the required supervision this month?

NO SUPERVISION **Contact your supervisor/agency**
Supervision is required to practice.

SUPERVISED **You're in compliance**
Keep records.

Making supervision work

1. **Know your supervisor** — Who is responsible for you.
2. **Schedule** — Supervision contacts each month.
3. **Be observed** — With clients, as required.
4. **Ask questions** — Use supervision to learn.
5. **Apply feedback** — Change what was asked.
6. **Track it** — Keep your own records.

On the job

- **Feedback:** receiving and applying feedback professionally is part of the role.
- **Responsibility:** the RBT is also responsible for making sure supervision happens.

Key words

supervision | % of hours | contacts | observation | feedback

Exam traps

- **RBTs cannot practice without ongoing supervision**
- **Supervision must include observation with a client**
- **Requirements can change: confirm with the current BACB handbook**

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CARD 84 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Seeking Clinical Direction

When in doubt, **ask** : don't improvise.



What it is

Seeking clinical direction means asking your supervisor how to proceed when a situation isn't covered by the plan or you are unsure.

It protects the client and keeps treatment consistent.

Ask for direction when

- The plan doesn't cover the situation
- Procedures are unclear
- Data show no progress or worsening
- Caregivers request changes
- You notice something new

Tell the difference

Are you about to try something that isn't in the plan?

YES **Stop and ask your supervisor**
Get direction first.

NO **Proceed with the plan**
As written.

Step by step

1. **Notice** — Something isn't clear or covered.
2. **Pause** — Don't improvise new procedures.
3. **Describe** — Objectively, with data.
4. **Ask** — Specific questions.
5. **Apply** — The direction you receive.
6. **Document** — The guidance and when it was given.

On the job

- **Example:** a new behavior appears (biting) → keep everyone safe, then ask your supervisor how to respond.
- **Good habit:** write questions down during the week for your supervision meeting.

Key words

clinical direction | supervisor | scope | consistency

Exam traps

- RBTs don't design or change procedures on their own
- Asking for help is professional, not a weakness
- New behaviors: keep safe, then seek direction

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CARD 85 | DOCUMENTATION • 13%

Timely Documentation and Corrections

Write it **on time** and fix errors **the right way**.



What it is

Documentation must be completed **within your agency's deadline** (often the same day). Late notes are less accurate and can cause billing problems.

Errors are corrected openly, following agency policy, never hidden.

Correcting errors

✓ **Correct**

Follow policy: e.g., single line, initials, date, or an addendum.

✗ **Never**

White-out, erasing, backdating or changing data.

Tell the difference

Are you changing a note after it was submitted?

AFTER **Use the agency's correction process**

Addendum or late entry, clearly marked.

BEFORE **Complete it on time**

Before the deadline.

Step by step

1. **During session** — Record data live.
2. **Right after** — Write the note.
3. **Review** — Check all fields and times.
4. **Submit** — Before the deadline.
5. **Mistake?** — Use the correction process.
6. **Late?** — Label it as a late entry, per policy.

On the job

- **Example:** you notice a wrong end time the next day → submit a correction/addendum as your agency requires.
- **Integrity:** documentation must always match what really happened.

Key words

timely | addendum | late entry | correction | integrity

Exam traps

- Never backdate or alter documentation to hide an error
- Erasing or using white-out on records is not acceptable
- Late entries must be clearly labeled as late

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CARD 86 | ETHICS • 15%

The RBT Ethics Code at a Glance

The rules that guide **every decision** an RBT makes.



What it is

The **RBT Ethics Code** is published by the BACB. Every RBT must follow it to keep the credential.

Its goal: **protect clients**, provide quality services and keep the profession trustworthy.

Three big areas

- **1.** General responsibilities (honesty, dignity, competence, conflicts)
- **2.** Providing services (follow the plan, data, documentation, confidentiality)
- **3.** Responsibilities to the BACB and your supervisor (supervision, self-reporting)

Read the full, current code at bacb.com.

Tell the difference

Does this action put the client's best interest first?

YES **Likely ethical**
Check the code and your agency policy.

NO **Stop and consult**
Talk to your supervisor first.

Core ideas

1. **Client first**
   Their welfare and dignity.
2. **Honesty**
   Accurate data, notes and billing.
3. **Competence**
   Only what you're trained to do.
4. **Supervision**
   Practice under your supervisor.
5. **Confidentiality**
   Protect client information.
6. **Boundaries**
   Avoid conflicts and multiple relationships.

On the job

- **On the exam:** ethics questions usually describe a dilemma: choose the answer that protects the client and involves the supervisor.
- **Policy:** agency rules can be stricter than the code; follow both.

Key words

RBT Ethics Code | BACB | client welfare | integrity

Exam traps

- The best ethical answer usually includes informing your supervisor
- Agency policy doesn't replace the Ethics Code; follow both
- Ethics questions test judgment, not memorized numbers

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CARD 87 | ETHICS • 15%

Scope of Practice: What an RBT Doesn't Do

Know where your role **ends**.



What it is

The RBT **implements** behavior-analytic services designed by a qualified supervisor (BCBA or BCaBA).

The RBT does **not** design treatment, make clinical decisions or practice independently.

RBT vs BCBA

RBT
Implements
Runs programs, collects data, follows plans, reports.

BCBA
Designs
Assessments, treatment plans, data-based decisions, supervision.

Tell the difference

Is the task about designing, changing or deciding on treatment?

DECIDING Outside RBT scope
That's the supervisor's role.

IMPLEMENTING Within RBT scope
Implementing as written.

Can the RBT...?

1. **Design programs** — No: the BCBA does.
2. **Change goals or procedures** — No: ask the supervisor.
3. **Interpret assessments** — No: you may assist only.
4. **Give diagnoses** — No: never.
5. **Supervise other RBTs** — No: not part of the RBT role.
6. **Implement & record** — Yes: that's your role.

On the job

- **Example:** a teacher asks you to write a new behavior plan → explain your role and connect them with the BCBA.
- **Titles:** never present yourself as a behavior analyst or therapist with clinical authority.

Key words

scope | implement | design | supervisor | role

Exam traps

- RBTs implement; BCBAs design and decide
- RBTs can't practice without supervision
- Assisting with an assessment ≠ conducting it independently

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CARD 88 | ETHICS • 15%

Multiple Relationships

Don't mix your **professional role** with a **personal** one.



What it is

A **multiple relationship** happens when you have a professional relationship with a client or family AND another relationship (friend, business partner, babysitter, romantic).

They can harm objectivity and the client. RBTs avoid them and tell their supervisor if one arises.

Examples

✗ **Avoid**
Babysitting for a client's family on weekends.

✗ **Avoid**
Becoming friends with a client's parent on social media.

✗ **Never**
Romantic or sexual relationships with clients or caregivers.

Tell the difference

Is there a second, non-professional relationship with the client or family?

YES **Multiple relationship**
Avoid it; inform your supervisor.

NO **Professional only**
Keep it that way.

Step by step

1. **Notice it** — A personal tie is forming.
2. **Pause** — Don't accept the extra role.
3. **Be kind** — Decline politely.
4. **Inform** — Tell your supervisor.
5. **Follow guidance** — The agency may adjust the case.
6. **Document** — As advised.

On the job

- **Unavoidable?:** in small towns you may already know a family: tell your supervisor right away.
- **Kind decline:** "I really appreciate it, but I'm not able to because of my professional role."

Key words

dual relationship | conflict of interest | objectivity | boundaries

Exam traps

- Babysitting for a client's family is a multiple relationship
- Romantic/sexual relationships with clients or caregivers are prohibited
- If a multiple relationship can't be avoided, inform the supervisor

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CARD 89 | ETHICS • 15%

Gifts

A kind gesture can create a **conflict**.



What it is

Families may want to thank you with gifts. Accepting gifts can create **conflicts of interest** or a sense of obligation.

Follow the **RBT Ethics Code** and your **agency's gift policy**. When in doubt, decline politely and tell your supervisor.

Think it through

?

Small gesture

A drawing or card from the child: check your agency's policy.

✗

Money / valuable

Cash, gift cards, expensive items: decline.

Tell the difference

Could accepting this affect your objectivity or create an obligation?

YES **Decline politely**
Inform your supervisor.

NO **Check policy**
Some agencies allow tiny tokens of thanks.

Step by step

1. **Thank them** — Show appreciation.
2. **Check policy** — Agency rule and the Ethics Code.
3. **Decline if needed** — Kind and clear.
4. **Inform** — Tell your supervisor.
5. **Don't give gifts** — Avoid giving gifts to families too.
6. **Document** — If your agency requires.

On the job

- **Example:** a parent offers a $50 gift card at the holidays → thank them, decline, tell your supervisor.
- **Kind decline:** "That's so thoughtful! I'm not able to accept gifts, but thank you."

Key words

gift | conflict of interest | policy | decline

Exam traps

- Cash and gift cards should be declined
- Follow both the Ethics Code and agency policy
- Tell your supervisor about gift offers

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CARD 90 | ETHICS • 15%

Social Media and Photos

Clients **never** appear on your social media.



What it is

Posting about clients, even without names, can **reveal their identity** and violate confidentiality.

Photos or videos of clients are taken only for clinical purposes, with consent and as your agency allows.

Social media rules

- No photos or videos of clients on personal devices (unless agency-approved)
- No posts about sessions, clients or families
- Avoid friending or following clients' families
- Don't reply to families about clients through social media

Tell the difference

Could anyone identify the client from what you post or share?

YES — Don't post it
It's a confidentiality violation.

NOT SURE — Still check policy
Most agencies ban any client-related posts.

Step by step

1. **Separate** — Keep personal and professional life apart.
2. **No client content** — Ever, on personal accounts.
3. **Friend requests** — Politely decline from families.
4. **Messages** — Redirect to official channels.
5. **Mistake?** — Delete and tell your supervisor.
6. **Know policy** — Your agency's media rules.

On the job

- **Example:** a cute art project made by a client → don't post it, even without the name.
- **Families:** "I keep my social media private, but you can reach me through the agency."

Key words

confidentiality | consent | privacy | social media

Exam traps

- Removing the name doesn't make a client post OK
- Friending families can create a multiple relationship
- Report any accidental posting immediately

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CARD 91 | ETHICS • 15%

Confidentiality

What happens in services **stays protected**.



What it is

Confidentiality means protecting all information about clients: names, diagnoses, behavior, family details, data and records.

Share it only with authorized people, for professional purposes, and only what is necessary.

OK or not?

✓ **OK**

Discussing a case in supervision with your BCBA.

✗ **Not OK**

Talking about a client with friends, even without the name.

Tell the difference

Does this person have authorization AND a professional need to know?

YES **Share the minimum necessary**
Following agency policy.

NO **Don't share**
Redirect politely.

Protecting confidentiality

1. **Private places** — Don't discuss cases in public.
2. **Secure records** — Lock and log out.
3. **Need to know** — Share only when required.
4. **Releases** — Follow consent forms for outside providers.
5. **Families** — Don't share one family's info with another.
6. **Breach?** — Report immediately.

On the job

- **Example:** at the park, a neighbor asks about "the boy you work with" → "I can't talk about my work, sorry!"
- **Exceptions:** safety and mandated reporting follow the law and agency policy.

Key words

confidential | need to know | consent | breach | privacy

Exam traps

- Confidentiality applies even after services end
- Leaving out the name may still identify a client
- Mandated reporting is a legal exception

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CARD 92 | ETHICS • 15%

Professional Boundaries

Be **warm and friendly** while staying **professional**.



What it is

Professional boundaries keep the relationship focused on the client's needs. Friendly is good; personal involvement is not.

Clear boundaries prevent conflicts and protect everyone.

Friendly vs personal

✓ **Friendly**
Polite small talk, warmth, respect.

✗ **Too personal**
Sharing personal problems, borrowing money, private texting.

Tell the difference

Does this help the client's treatment, or is it about your personal relationship?

TREATMENT **Professional**
Keep going.

PERSONAL **Boundary issue**
Step back and inform your supervisor.

Healthy boundaries

1. **Use official channels**
   Agency phone/email for contact.
2. **Keep it about the client**
   In conversations.
3. **Limit self-disclosure**
   Little personal information.
4. **No favors**
   Rides, loans, extra jobs.
5. **Respect the home**
   Follow the family's rules.
6. **Ask**
   If unsure, check with the supervisor.

On the job

- **Example:** a parent invites you to a family party → thank them, decline politely, tell your supervisor.
- **Home sessions:** be a professional guest: on time, prepared, respectful.

Key words

boundaries | professional | self-disclosure | conflict

Exam traps

- Being friendly is fine; becoming friends is a boundary problem
- Doing favors for a family can create a multiple relationship
- Communicate through agency-approved channels

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CARD 93 | ETHICS • 15%

Client Dignity

Treat every client with **respect**, always.



What it is

Every client has the right to be treated with **dignity and respect**, regardless of age, diagnosis or behavior.

This includes privacy, choices, age-appropriate materials and respectful language.

Dignity in practice

- Use respectful, person-first or preferred language
- Protect privacy (bathroom, dressing)
- Offer choices whenever possible
- Use age-appropriate materials and activities
- Never humiliate, threaten or tease
- Talk WITH the client, not about them in front of them

Tell the difference

Would this be respectful if it were done to you or someone you love?

YES Respectful
Keep doing it.

NO Stop
Change it and talk to your supervisor.

Step by step

1. **Greet** — Say hello to the client, not just the parent.
2. **Explain** — Tell the client what's next.
3. **Choices** — Offer them in each session.
4. **Privacy** — Close doors, cover, step out when appropriate.
5. **Language** — Never mock or label.
6. **Speak up** — Report disrespect to your supervisor.

On the job

- **Example:** a teen client gets age-appropriate materials, not toddler toys.
- **Talking:** don't discuss a client's behavior in front of them as if they weren't there.

Key words

dignity | respect | choice | privacy | age-appropriate

Exam traps

- Dignity applies to every client, no matter the behavior
- Humiliation or teasing is never acceptable
- Choices and privacy are part of ethical services

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CARD 94 | ETHICS • 15%

Responding to Unethical Requests

When someone asks you to do the **wrong thing**.



What it is

Sometimes a caregiver, colleague or even an employer may ask you to do something that goes against the **Ethics Code**.

You must **not comply** and should report it to your supervisor (or follow the agency's process).

Examples of unethical requests

- **Billing for a session that didn't happen**
- **Changing data to look better**
- **Skipping supervision**
- **Doing a procedure you're not trained for**
- **Sharing confidential information**

Tell the difference

Would doing this violate the Ethics Code, the law or agency policy?

YES **Decline and report**
To your supervisor or agency, per policy.

NO **Proceed**
If it's within ethics and your role.

Step by step

1. **Recognize it** — Something doesn't feel right.
2. **Check** — Ethics Code and agency policy.
3. **Decline** — Politely and clearly.
4. **Report** — To your supervisor.
5. **Escalate** — If the supervisor is involved, follow agency/BACB processes.
6. **Document** — What happened and when.

On the job

- **Example:** a coworker asks you to sign their session note → decline and inform your supervisor.
- **Protection:** following the code protects your credential.

Key words

decline | report | integrity | violation

Exam traps

- **"My boss told me to" doesn't make an unethical action OK**
- **Falsifying data or billing is never acceptable**
- **Decline first, then report**

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CARD 95 | ETHICS • 15%

Self-Reporting to the BACB

Some events must be **reported by you**.



What it is

The RBT Ethics Code requires RBTs to **self-report** certain events to the BACB (and to their supervisor), within the deadlines set by the BACB.

Examples include legal issues and conditions that could affect your ability to practice safely.

Events that may require self-reporting

- **Legal charges, convictions or investigations**
- **Physical or mental conditions that impair safe practice**
- **Actions by other agencies or licensing bodies**
- **Other events listed in the current code**

Check the current RBT Ethics Code for the full list and deadlines.

Tell the difference

Did something happen that the Ethics Code lists as a self-report event?

YES — Report it
To the BACB within the required time, and inform your supervisor.

NO — Keep in compliance
Review the code periodically.

Step by step

1. **Know the list** — Read the self-report section.
2. **Event happens** — Note the date.
3. **Report** — To the BACB, as required.
4. **Inform** — Your supervisor/agency.
5. **Follow up** — Provide requested information.
6. **Keep records** — Copies of what you sent.

On the job

- **Honesty:** failing to self-report is itself an ethics violation.
- **Supervisor:** also keep your supervisor informed of anything that affects your work.

Key words

self-report | BACB | deadline | compliance

Exam traps

- **Not self-reporting a required event is a violation**
- **Self-reporting goes to the BACB, not only to your supervisor**
- **Deadlines are set by the BACB: know them**

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CARD 96 | ETHICS • 15%

Cultural Responsiveness

Respect each family's **culture, values and language**.



What it is

Cultural responsiveness means respecting and adapting to clients' cultures, languages, beliefs and family values.

RBTs don't discriminate and should tell their supervisor if cultural factors affect treatment.

In practice

- Learn about the family's preferences and routines
- Respect beliefs and traditions
- Use interpreters when needed, as the agency provides
- Avoid assumptions and stereotypes
- Reflect on your own biases

Tell the difference

Is a cultural factor affecting how the family experiences treatment?

YES **Talk to your supervisor**
Goals and procedures may need adjusting.

NO **Continue respectfully**
Stay open and curious.

Step by step

1. **Listen** — Ask about family routines and values.
2. **Respect** — Shoes off at the door, meal times, holidays.
3. **Adapt language** — Materials in the family's language when possible.
4. **No judgment** — Different ≠ wrong.
5. **Report** — Cultural concerns to your supervisor.
6. **Learn** — Seek training on diversity.

On the job

- **Example:** a family prefers that the father is present in sessions → share with the supervisor to plan around it.
- **Non-discrimination:** never treat a client differently because of race, religion, gender, language or culture.

Key words

culture | diversity | bias | respect | non-discrimination

Exam traps

- Discrimination is never acceptable
- Cultural concerns about treatment go to the supervisor
- Avoid assumptions based on stereotypes

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CARD 97 | ETHICS • 15%

Representing Your Credential Correctly

Say **exactly** what you are: a **Registered Behavior Technician**.



What it is

RBTs must **accurately represent** their credential, training and role to clients, families and others.

You may use the RBT credential only while it is **active** and in good standing.

Accurate or not?

✓ **Accurate**
"I'm a Registered Behavior Technician, supervised by a BCBA."

✗ **Misleading**
"I'm a behavior analyst" or "I'm the therapist in charge."

Tell the difference

Does your description make people think you have more training or authority than you do?

YES **Correct it**
Explain your real role.

NO **Accurate**
Keep it that way.

Step by step

1. **Use the title**
   Registered Behavior Technician (RBT).
2. **Explain the role**
   You implement plans designed by a BCBA.
3. **Active credential**
   Renew on time.
4. **Expired?**
   Stop using the title.
5. **Correct others**
   If someone calls you a BCBA.
6. **Signatures**
   Use the correct credential on documents.

On the job

- **Example:** a parent introduces you as "the doctor" → kindly explain you're an RBT and who your supervisor is.
- **Resume:** list your credential and training accurately.

Key words

credential | RBT | accurate | active | role

Exam traps

- Never present yourself as a BCBA or clinician in charge
- Using the RBT title with an expired credential is a violation
- Correct misunderstandings about your role

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CARD 98 | ETHICS • 15%

Working Within Your Competence

Do only what you've been **trained** to do.



What it is

Competence means performing only the tasks you have been trained and are competent to perform, under supervision.

If you're asked to do something new, request **training and supervision** first.

Competent?

✓ **Trained**
Running DTT programs you were trained and observed on.

✗ **Not trained**
Using a crisis hold you've never been certified in.

Tell the difference

Have you been trained and observed doing this procedure?

YES **Proceed**
As written, under supervision.

NO **Ask for training first**
Don't attempt it alone.

Step by step

1. **Know your skills** — What you're trained to do.
2. **New procedure?** — Ask for training.
3. **Practice** — With feedback from your supervisor.
4. **Get observed** — Before doing it alone.
5. **Keep learning** — Ongoing training and feedback.
6. **Speak up** — If you feel unprepared.

On the job

- **Example:** you're asked to run a feeding program for the first time → ask your supervisor for training first.
- **Safety:** untrained procedures can harm the client.

Key words

competence | training | feedback | supervision

Exam traps

- Never perform a procedure you haven't been trained on
- Asking for training is the ethical choice
- Competence is maintained with ongoing supervision and feedback

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CARD 99 | ETHICS • 15%

Accurate Billing and Timesheets

Bill **only** for services **actually provided**.



What it is

Session notes and timesheets support billing to insurance and other payers. They must reflect **exactly** the services you provided.

Inaccurate billing can be **fraud**, and it violates the Ethics Code.

Accurate or not?

✓ **Accurate**
Session 3:00–4:45 → you record 3:00–4:45.

✗ **Fraud**
Recording 3:00–5:00 or billing a canceled session.

Tell the difference

Does what you recorded match exactly what happened?

YES **Submit it**
Accurate time and services.

NO **Correct it first**
Use your agency's correction process.

Step by step

1. **Real times** — Record actual start and end.
2. **Real services** — What you actually did.
3. **Canceled?** — Never bill it as provided.
4. **Breaks** — Follow agency rules for non-billable time.
5. **Mistakes** — Correct through the proper process.
6. **Pressure?** — Decline and report.

On the job

- **Example:** the family canceled at the door → document a cancellation, not a session.
- **Rounding:** don't round up time; follow agency rules exactly.

Key words

billing | timesheet | fraud | accurate | cancellation

Exam traps

- Billing for services not provided is fraud
- Session times must match the actual session
- Being asked by an employer doesn't make false billing OK

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CARD 100 | ETHICS • 15%

Ethics Decision Steps: Putting It Together

A simple routine for **any** ethics question.



What it is

Ethics questions on the exam usually describe a situation and ask what the RBT **should do first** or **best**.

The correct answer usually protects the client, follows the code, stays within the RBT role and involves the supervisor.

5 quick checks

- Is the client safe?
- Does this follow the Ethics Code?
- Is it within my role and training?
- Does my supervisor know?
- Is it documented?

Tell the difference

Does the answer option have the RBT act alone on a clinical or ethical issue?

ALONE **Probably wrong**
RBTs consult their supervisor.

WITH SUPERVISOR **Probably right**
If it protects the client and involves the supervisor.

The decision routine

1. **Identify** — What is the ethical issue?
2. **Safety** — Address immediate risk first.
3. **Check** — Ethics Code + agency policy.
4. **Consult** — Your supervisor.
5. **Act** — Follow the direction given.
6. **Document** — What happened and what you did.

On the job

- **Exam tip:** between two good answers, choose the one that keeps the client safe and involves the supervisor.
- **Avoid:** answers where the RBT confronts, investigates, ignores or decides alone.

Key words

safety | consult | document | client welfare | role

Exam traps

- "Do nothing" is rarely the right answer
- Confronting or investigating on your own is usually wrong
- Safety first, then supervisor, then documentation

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